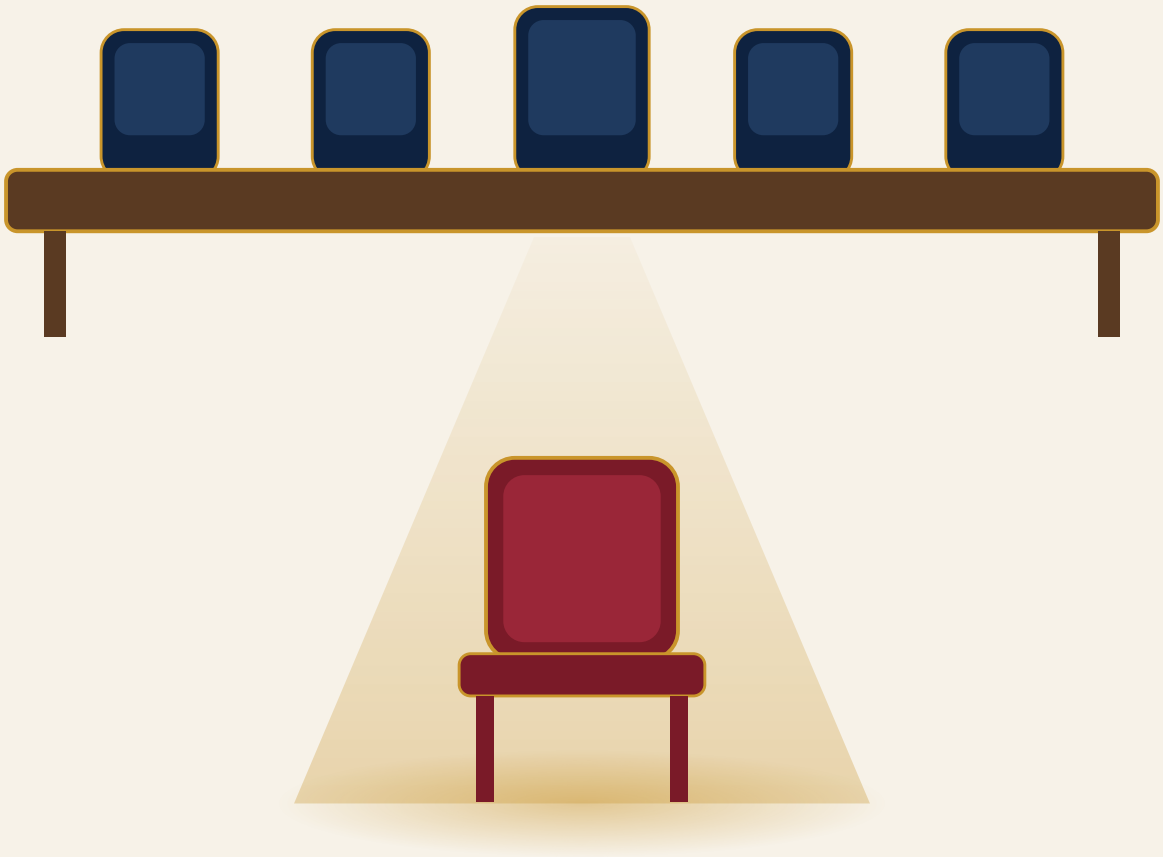
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The Personality Test

A Mentor's Guide to the UPSC Interview

The board is not looking for a perfect candidate.
It is looking for one it can trust.

Seven Pillars ◆ Real 2025–26 Boards ◆ 31 Model Answers ◆ 18 State Profiles

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ENGLISH EDITION

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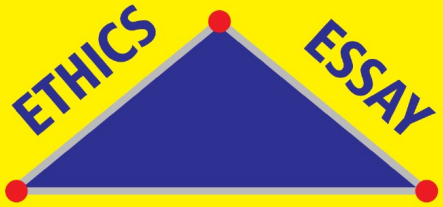
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AIR 02 CSE 2025



RAJESHWARI SUVE M
Ethics Test Series 2023 & 2025

AIR 03 CSE 2025



AKANSH DHULL
134 Marks in Ethics
Ethics & Essay Test Series 2023
Ethics Case Studies 2023

Essay Highest Marks

127 Marks in Essay



PRACHI SINGHAL
AIR 370 CSE 2025
Essay Test Series 2024

119 Marks in Essay



AKANSH DHULL
AIR 03 CSE 2025
Essay Mock Test 2023

Public Admin. (Optional) Highest Marks

291 Marks in PA



YASHASWI RAJ VARDHAN
AIR 11 CSE 2025
PA Foundation Batch 2023
PA Crash Course (Enrichment) Batch 2025

289 Marks in PA



SATVIK SHARMA
AIR 327 CSE 2025
PA Foundation Batch 2020
PA Test Series 2025

These candidates from Lukmaan IAS achieved remarkable ranks in UPSC CSE 2025, highlighting the institute's strong support in Ethics, Essay, test series, and optional subjects like Public Administration.

Yashaswi Raj Vardhan (AIR 11): Secured highest rank for **Public Administration optional (291 marks, top score).** Enrolled in Public Admin Foundation 2023, Crash Course 2025, and Ethics Crash Course 2025. Achieved in second attempt through discipline and consistency.

Akansh Dhull (AIR 3): Scored 1057 total marks in fourth attempt. Courses: Ethics Test Series 2023, Case Studies 2023, Essay Mock Test 2023, IGP. Standout scores: **Ethics 134, Essay 119, Interview 193.** B.Com from SRCC (DU); from Chandigarh/Haryana; optional Commerce & Accountancy.

Rajeshwari Suve M (AIR 2): Enrolled in Ethics Test Series 2023 & 2025. From Vadipatti, Madurai (TN); B.E. Electrical & Electronics from Anna University; optional Sociology. Serving as Deputy Collector (Training) in TN govt post-TNPSC Group 1.

Ishan Bhatnagar (AIR 5): From Lucknow (UP), resides in Bhopal (MP); born 2001. Courses: GS Mains Test Series 2023, Essay & Ethics Test Series 2025. Son of Amitabh Bhatnagar (Good Governance Institute) and Prof. Vinita Bhatnagar.

This group showcases Lukmaan IAS's impact on high scorers, especially in Ethics (multiple 130+ scores) and structured test prep.

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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

If I were mentoring you, I would not begin with a question bank. I would begin by changing how you see the room. This book is written in that spirit. It is not a list of things every aspirant already knows about the interview. It is a guide to becoming the kind of person the board is hoping to meet.

Part I explains what the board is really assessing, what the last two results reveal, and how to build the habits of thought and temperament that show up in the room.

Part II breaks preparation into seven pillars: composure, articulation, consistency, DAF dissection, situational ethics, the optional, and current developments. Each pillar has an explanation, numbered steps and a worked illustration.

Part III takes you inside real boards: ten CSE 2025 interviews analysed board by board, toppers in their own words, question sets for common backgrounds, and a template for your home state and district.

Part IV is a ready reckoner for the final weeks. Model answers to all 31 expected questions are in Part V.

Part V gives model answers to all 31 questions in the question bank, and **Part VI** has one-page profiles of 18 states for home-state questions.

> **Quick facts: the Personality Test**
>
> **Stage:** the third and final stage of the Civil Services Examination, after Prelims and Mains.
>
> **Marks:** 275, added to the Mains written total of 1,750, for a final total of 2,025.
>
> **Board:** a Chairperson and usually four members; about 25 to 40 minutes.
>
> **Venue:** UPSC, Dholpur House, Shahjahan Road, New Delhi.
>
> **Language:** English, Hindi, or the Indian language chosen for the compulsory language paper in Mains.
>
> **Purpose:** to assess personal suitability for a career in public service, not to test knowledge.

> **Reading the visuals**
>
> Every figure is meant to be redrawn by you. Sketch the iceberg, the four-beat rhythm and the self-rating radar in your own notebook. Drawing them fixes the idea far better than reading about it.

PART I

Understanding the Personality Test

Mindset before method

CHAPTER 1

What the Board Is Really Asking

Every board member, whatever they ask, is quietly answering one question: “Would I trust this person as my SDM when a flood hits, a riot breaks out, or a minister calls at midnight?”

Your words are only the tip of what they notice. Most of their marks come from what sits beneath.

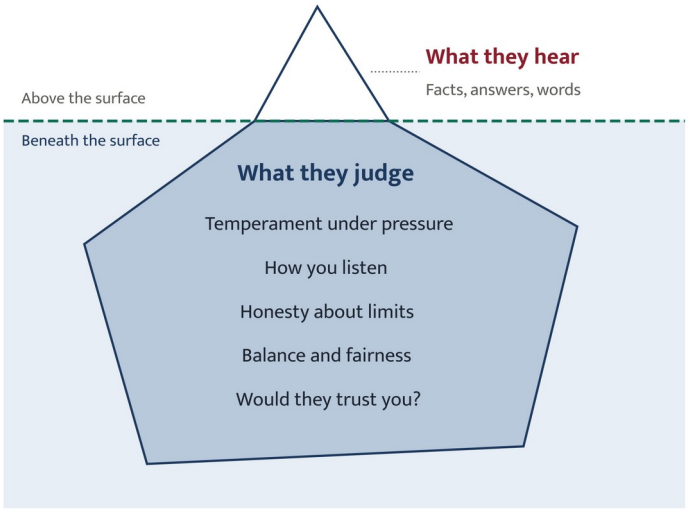


Figure 1. The interview iceberg: what the board hears versus what it judges

So your preparation should work mostly below the waterline. Facts can be crammed in a week. Temperament has to be grown.

The seven qualities the board scores

UPSC's own notification says the interview assesses personal suitability for public service, and names seven qualities. Each one tends to surface through a particular kind of question. Once you see the map, the interview becomes far less mysterious.



Figure 2. The seven qualities in the UPSC notification, and where each usually shows up

Notice that none of the seven is "knowledge". Knowledge is only the raw material through which these qualities become visible.

CHAPTER 2

What the Numbers Say

It is tempting to treat the interview as a formality after Mains. The last two results show why that is a mistake.

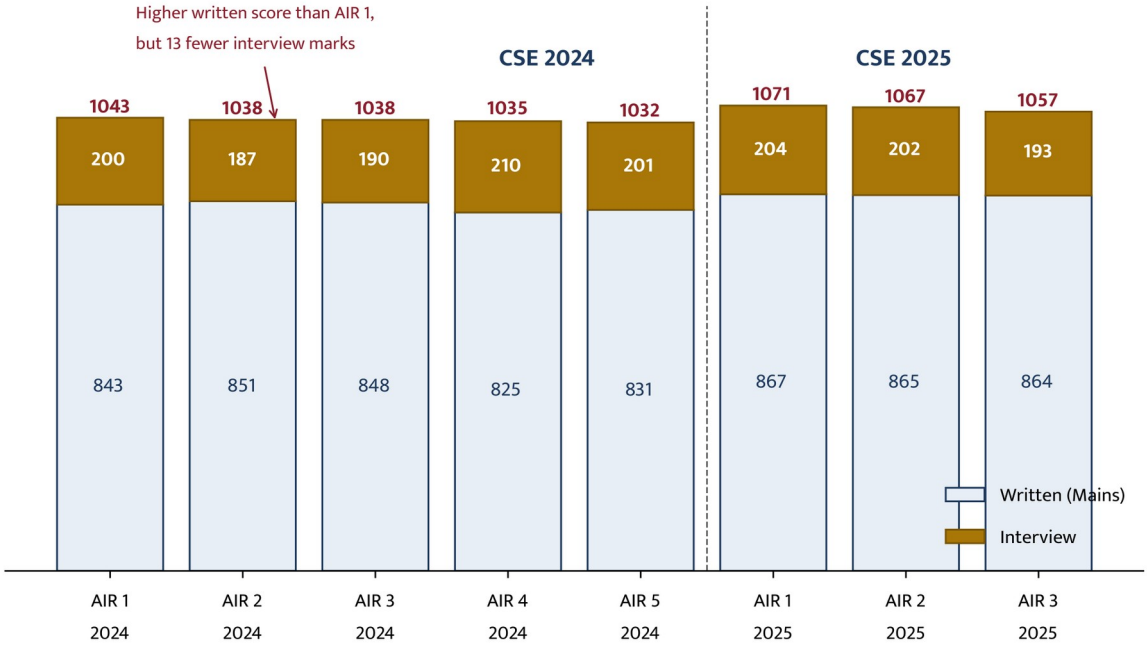


Figure 3. Written and interview marks of the top rankers, CSE 2024 and CSE 2025 (out of 1,750 and 275)

- **The interview decided AIR 1 in 2024.** Harshita Goyal (AIR 2) outscored Shakti Dubey in the written papers, 851 to 843. Shakti's 200 in the interview against Harshita's 187 put her 5 marks ahead overall.
- **A strong interview lifts a modest written score.** Shah Margi Chirag had the lowest written score of the 2024 top five (825), but the highest interview score among them (210), which carried her to AIR 4.
- **Margins at the top are tiny.** In CSE 2025, Anuj Agnihotri (AIR 1) scored 867 + 204 = 1,071. The top three were separated by just 14 marks, and their interview scores ranged from 193 to 204.
- **The ceiling is high.** The highest interview score in CSE 2025 was 225, by Tejaswini Singh (AIR 62). A score of roughly 65–75% of 275, about 180 to 205, is generally considered strong.

> **What this means for you**
>
> A 20-mark swing in the interview can move you by well over a hundred ranks, and with it, between services. Treat the Personality Test as a full paper worth six weeks of serious work.

CHAPTER 3

Before the DAF, Know Your Own Story

Most candidates prepare their DAF like a minefield, trying to guess where the traps are. Treat it as a mirror instead. Sit with each line and ask why it is there and what it says about you.

> **Exercise: the five "so what?" ladder**
>
> Take "Why civil services?" and ask yourself "so what?" five times, writing each answer down. By the fourth or fifth round you will reach something true and specific. Repeat the ladder for your hobby, your hometown and your optional.

Compare these two answers to "Why civil services?"

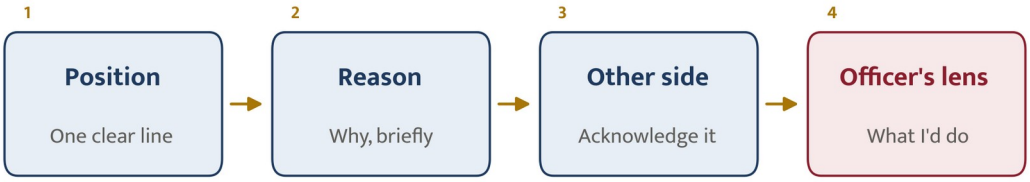
Mechanical answer	Real answer
"I want to serve the nation and bring change at the grassroots level."	"When my grandfather's land record was wrong, it took us three years and eleven visits to the tehsil to fix it. I kept thinking that one sensitive officer could have ended it in a week. I want to be that officer."
Could come from any of 3,000 candidates. The board forgets it instantly.	Could only come from you. It also opens a natural follow-up, on land-record digitisation and SVAMITVA, that you can handle well.

Your optional is itself a story. Why did a subject about how the state works pull you in? One honest sentence on that is worth more than ten thinkers quoted from memory.

CHAPTER 4

How to Think Out Loud

Board members do not want essays. They want to watch a mind at work. Train yourself in a simple four-beat rhythm.



About 30 to 60 seconds in total

Figure 4. The four-beat answer rhythm

Here is how that sounds for a question a Public Administration candidate is likely to face: "Is Weberian bureaucracy outdated?"

> **Worked example**
>
> **Position:** *"Not outdated, Sir, but incomplete.*
>
> **Reason:** *Rules, hierarchy and records are what protect a poor citizen from arbitrary power, and in a tehsil office that still matters.*
>
> **Other side:** *At the same time, rigid rule-following can make the system slow and indifferent, which is what NPM and citizen-centric reforms tried to fix.*
>
> **Officer's lens:** *As a district officer, I would keep the Weberian spine for accountability but add service-delivery timelines and grievance feedback, the way public services guarantee acts try to do."*

It takes about 40 seconds. It is balanced without being vague, and it ends in action. That last beat is what separates an aspirant from a future officer.

CHAPTER 5

Personality Grooming: Six Weeks of Habits

Personality is not performed on the day. It is what leaks out when you are tired and surprised. So we build it through daily habits.

Listening

Most candidates start answering before the question ends. Let the full question land, pause for two seconds, then speak. That pause reads as maturity. Rushing reads as anxiety.

An opinion journal

Every day, pick one issue, such as One Nation One Election, freebies, AI in policing or the caste census. Write your view in five lines, then write the strongest case against it. Within a month you will stop panicking at opinion questions, because you will have practised holding two views at once.

Real conversations

Spend an hour with a patwari, an ASHA worker, a constable, a ration dealer or a farmer. Ask what frustrates them about the system. When you later talk about last-mile delivery, you will speak with texture no coaching note can give. Boards can tell the difference between someone who has read about a PHC and someone who has sat in one.

Voice and body

Read one editorial aloud each day, slowly, and record it. Listen for speed, filler words ("basically", "actually", "like") and a rising tone that makes statements sound like questions. Sit tall, rest your hands on the table or your lap, and let your gaze move gently across the board.

Training for stress

Ask a friend to interrupt you, contradict you, even mock your answer. Practise one calm line: "That's a fair point, Sir. I would still hold my view, because…" Or, if they are right: "I hadn't thought of it that way. You're right." Both are strong answers. Irritation is the only weak one.

Protecting your mind

Take three to five good mocks, not fifteen. Too many mocks make you rehearsed and anxious, answering what the last panel wanted rather than what you believe. Sleep, walk, and cut down on Telegram groups.

Allowing warmth

A small smile, a light moment of humour when the board offers one, and genuine curiosity about a member's question all make you human. The board spends the whole day with nervous candidates. Someone at ease is memorable.

Dress and presence

Wear formal, conservative, well-fitted clothes in which you feel comfortable. Men usually choose dark trousers, a light shirt, a tie and black shoes; women usually choose a saree or formal business wear. Avoid flashy accessories and strong perfume. Rehearse once in the clothes you will wear, so nothing feels new on the day.

A suggested six-week rhythm

Week	Focus	Daily practice
1	Self-discovery	"So what?" ladder for each DAF line; write your real story in one page
2	DAF depth	District profile, hobby depth, optional basics; begin opinion journal
3	Field texture	Two or three conversations with frontline workers; note what surprised you
4	Thinking aloud	Four-beat answers spoken aloud and recorded; first mock interview
5	Stress and poise	Friend-led interruption drills; two mocks spaced apart; review recordings
6	Settling	Newspaper and DAF revision only; sleep, walk, no new material

Track yourself: a weekly self-rating

Every Sunday, rate yourself from 1 to 5 on each of the seven qualities, ideally after watching a recording of yourself. Ask a friend or mock panelist to rate you too, and compare. The gaps between your view and theirs are where the real work lies.

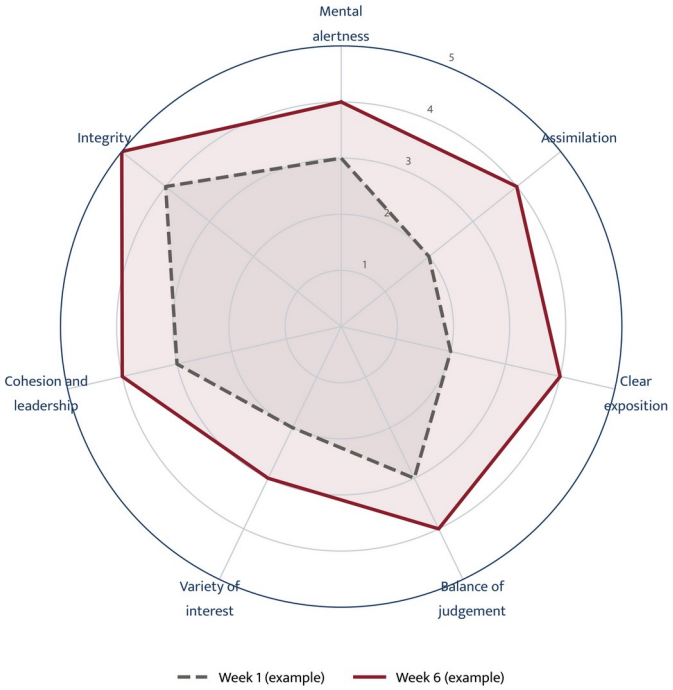


Figure 5. An example self-rating, week 1 against week 6. Draw your own shape each week.

CHAPTER 6

Managing the 30 Minutes

How the conversation widens

Experienced interviewers describe the conversation as unfolding in roughly four stages. The board usually starts with what you are most comfortable with, yourself. It then moves to your subjects of study, widens to current social, political and economic issues, and finally asks pointed questions that test your judgement and integrity.

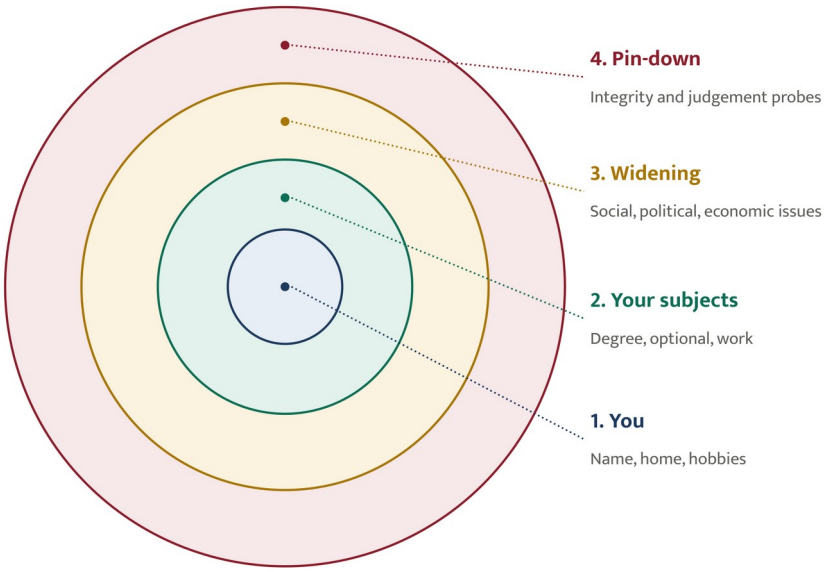


Figure 6. The board widens the net, ring by ring

This is why the first minutes are gentle: the board is letting you settle. It also means the hardest questions often come late, when you may be tiring. Save some energy for the outer ring.

Where to look

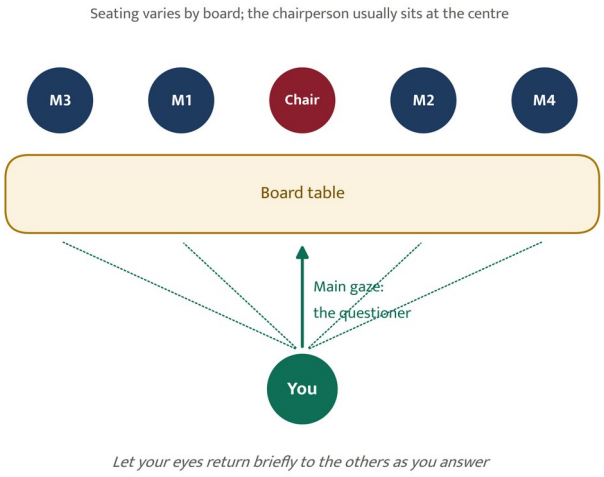


Figure 7. Eye contact in the room

Give most of your attention to the member who asked the question, but let your gaze take in the others as you answer. The board is marking together, and a candidate who speaks only to one member seems to forget the rest of the room.

The emotional arc

Nearly every interview follows this emotional shape. Knowing it in advance takes away its power over you.

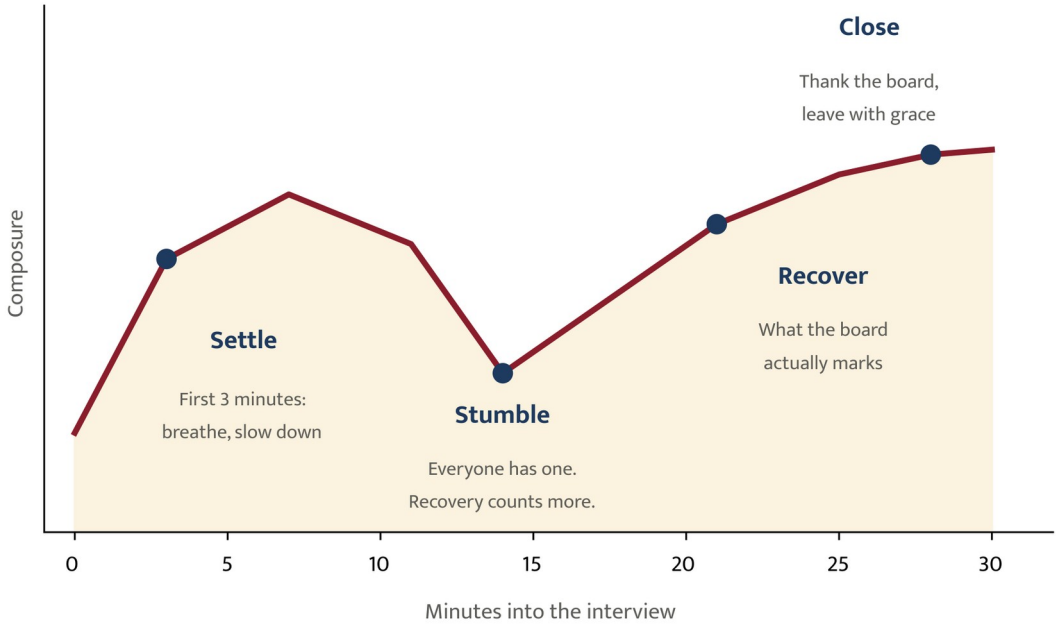


Figure 8. The emotional arc of a typical interview

Almost everyone stumbles somewhere. What stays with the board is how you recover. Here is how to handle the five hardest moments.

Moment	What it tests	What to do or say
You don't know	Honesty, self-possession	"I'm sorry, Sir, I'm not aware of that. I'll read about it after this." Say it cleanly and move on. Don't let one gap spoil the next three answers.
A member disagrees	Conviction versus approval-seeking	Respect their point and hold yours if it is sound. Change your view only if they have shown you something new, and say so openly.
A trap or provocation	Balance, political neutrality	Step back from the loaded framing: "There are real achievements, Sir, like X. There are also gaps, like Y. As an officer, my focus would be on closing Y."
You made a mistake	Integrity	"Sir, may I correct something I said earlier? The figure was actually..." This often counts in your favour.
Silence after your answer	Composure	Don't rush to fill it. Silence is often the board thinking or writing. Sit comfortably in it.

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- ✓ Monthly PT Current Affairs (PIB + MCA) (Nov 2026 – Apr 2027) : 06
- ✓ Union Budget 2027-28 & Economic Survey 2026-27 Classes
- ✓ 1 Budget class + 3 Economic Survey classes : 04
- ✓ CSAT Classes : 22 (Recorded Videos)

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- ✓ 50-MCQ Reinforcement Tests (50-MCQRT) : 51
- ✓ GS Sectional Full-Length Tests (GS-SFLT): 12
- ✓ Current Affairs Full-Length Tests (CA-FLT): 5
- ✓ CSAT Sectional Full-Length Tests (CSAT-SFLT): 5
- ✓ Mock Full-Length Tests (GS + CSAT): 3
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PART II

Seven Pillars, Step by Step

Turning mindset into practice

CHAPTER 7

The Role of Composure

Composure is temperament made visible. The board will deliberately press, interrupt or contradict you, not to defeat you, but to see what a district would see during a crisis. A calm candidate with an average answer usually scores better than an agitated candidate with a brilliant one.

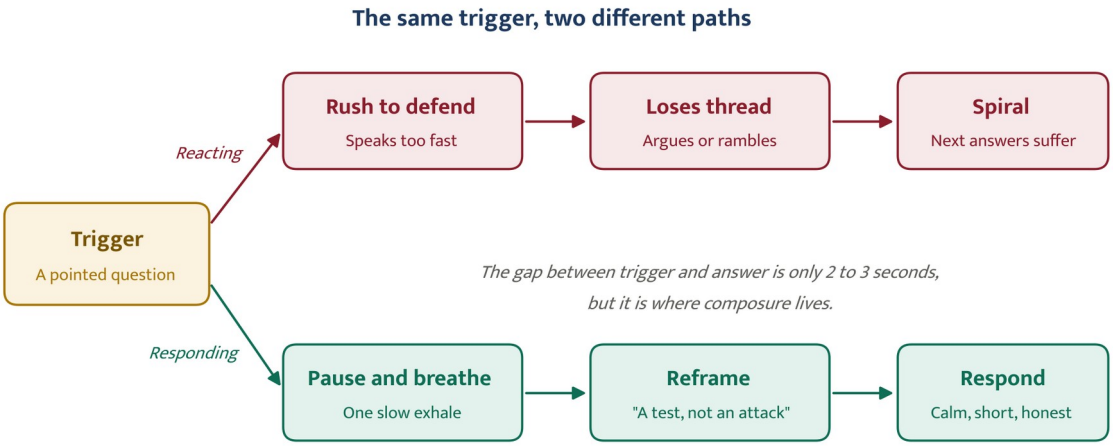


Figure 9. Reacting versus responding to the same trigger

Step 1. **Name your triggers.** List the five questions you dread most, such as gap years, number of attempts, leaving a job, a weak subject or a strong opinion you hold. Write a calm, honest answer to each. Fear shrinks once it has an answer.

Step 2. **Learn a physical reset.** Before a difficult answer, take one slow breath and make the exhale longer than the inhale. Keep your feet flat and your hands still. Nobody on the board will notice, but your voice will.

Step 3. **Carry one silent phrase.** “This is a test of temperament, not an attack.” Repeating it internally turns a threat into a task.

Step 4. **Buy time honestly.** “May I take a moment to think, Sir?” is a perfectly acceptable sentence. A thoughtful pause is better than a fast wrong turn.

Step 5. **Rehearse under pressure.** Ask a friend or mock panel to interrupt, contradict and hurry you. Watch the recording and note when your pace rises or your hands move.

Step 6. **Recover from a stumble.** Treat each question as a fresh start. The board remembers the recovery more than the mistake.

Step 7. **Protect your baseline.** Sleep, meals and a daily walk in the final week matter more than one more chapter. Composure is partly physical.

Illustration: "This is your fourth attempt. Why should we believe you'll succeed now?"

Reactive: *"Sir, attempts don't define a person. Many toppers took five or six attempts..."* (defensive, and implies the board is being unfair)

Composed: *"It's a fair question, Sir. In my first attempts, my answers were full of information but thin on analysis. Each attempt taught me something, and I think it has also made me more patient, which I hope will help me in the service."*

CHAPTER 8

Articulation and Communication

Articulation is not about fine English or Hindi. It is about making your thinking easy to follow. The board should never have to work to understand you.

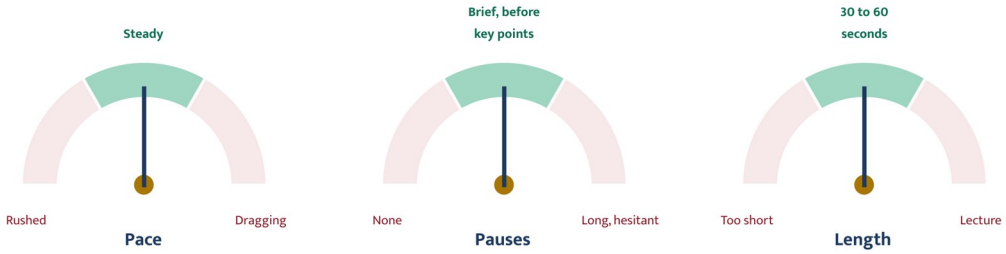


Figure 10. Three dials of delivery: aim for the green zone on each

Step 1. **Headline first.** Answer the question in your first sentence, then support it. "Yes, with safeguards" is a better opening than a history lesson.

Step 2. **Signpost.** "Two reasons, Sir. First... Second..." Signposts help the listener and discipline your own thinking.

Step 3. **Short sentences, one idea each.** Long sentences with many clauses sound like essays read aloud.

Step 4. **Concrete over abstract.** One real example, such as a scheme, a district or a statistic you are sure of, is worth five adjectives.

Step 5. **Replace fillers with pauses.** "Basically", "actually" and "you know" fill silence. A brief pause does the same job and sounds more assured.

Step 6. **Watch your pitch.** End statements on a falling tone. A rising tone makes a firm view sound like a question.

Step 7. **Stop when you've answered.** Trust the full stop. If the board wants more, they will ask, and that follow-up is itself a good sign.

Illustration: "Should civil servants be active on social media?"

Cluttered: *"So basically, Sir, social media is actually a very important tool in today's world, and there are many advantages and also some disadvantages, and we have to see both sides..."*

Clear: *"Yes, Sir, for communication, not for self-promotion. It helps in disasters, grievances and scheme awareness. But the conduct rules on neutrality still apply, so I'd use it for information, never for opinion."*

CHAPTER 9

Consistency

The board trusts a candidate when three things line up: what you wrote in the DAF, what you say in the room, and how you behave. A single contradiction can make the board doubt everything else.

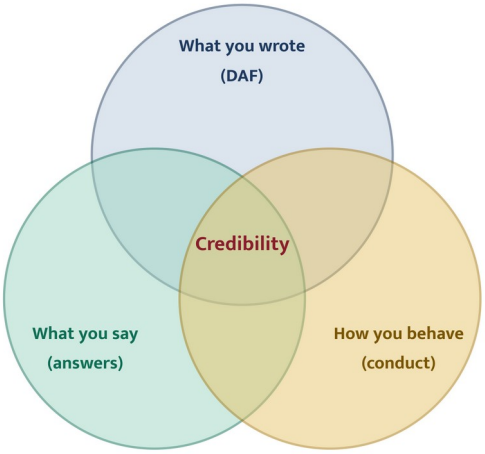


Figure 11. The three layers of consistency

Step 1. **Write your five core beliefs.** For example: rule of law, dignity of the poor, evidence over ideology, federal cooperation, honesty. Check every opinion you prepare against them.

Step 2. **Audit your DAF against your story.** If you say you love fieldwork, the board may ask why your first service preference points elsewhere. Prepare an honest answer.

Step 3. **Run a contradiction hunt.** Ask a friend to put the same issue to you in three different forms on different days, and compare your answers.

Step 4. **Own changes of mind.** "I used to think X. After Y, I now think Z." This is consistency of reasoning, which is more valuable than rigidity.

Step 5. **Match words with conduct.** If you speak about respect for women, address every board member with equal attention. If you speak about punctuality, arrive early. The board notices.

> **Illustration**
>
> Your DAF lists trekking as a hobby, but you haven't trekked for three years. Say so honestly: "Not recently, Sir, preparation took over. But my last trek to X taught me…" Claiming recent treks and then failing the follow-up questions does far more damage than admitting the gap.

CHAPTER 10

Dissecting DAF-Based Questions

Most of your interview grows out of your DAF, so dissect it systematically rather than guessing. Every entry can be drilled through six layers, and each layer brings you closer to administration.

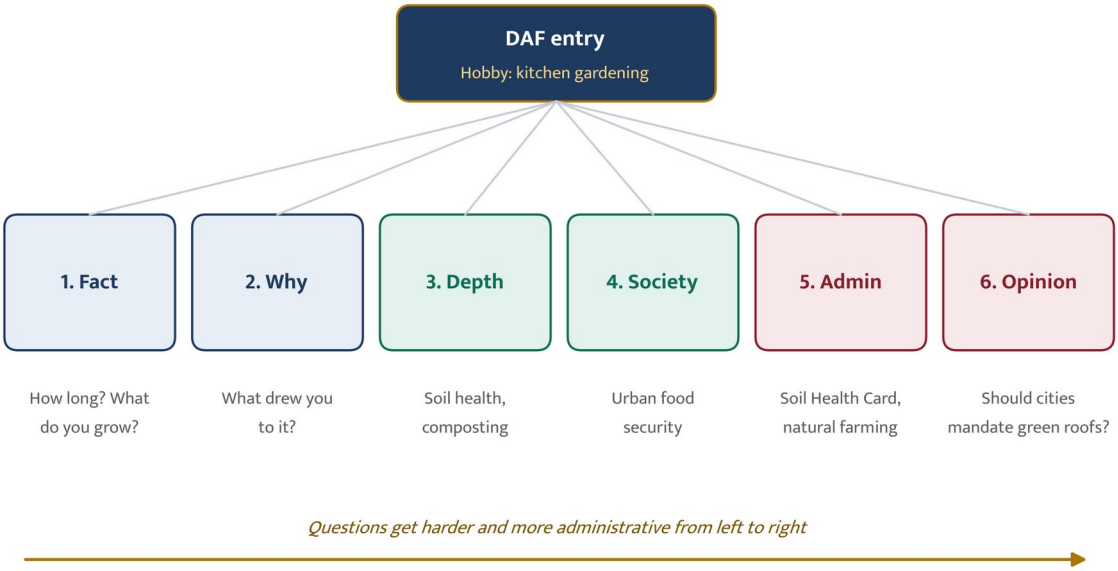


Figure 12. Drilling one DAF entry through six layers

Step 1. **List every entry.** Name, date and place of birth, schools, college, degree, work, optional, hobbies, achievements, extracurriculars, parents' occupations, home district and state, and service and cadre preferences.

Step 2. **Drill six layers.** For each entry: fact, why, depth, link to society, link to administration, and opinion or controversy.

Step 3. **Write 10 to 15 questions per entry.** Keep answers as bullet points, not scripts, so they stay natural.

Step 4. **Mark danger zones.** Gaps, job changes, a hobby you have neglected, surprising preferences. These deserve the most honest preparation.

Step 5. **Add a news layer.** For each entry, especially your district, state and degree, find what has happened in the last six months.

Step 6. **Get cross-questioned.** Hand your DAF to a friend and let them ask anything. Their questions will be less predictable than yours.

DAF entry	Sample questions across the layers
Name	What does it mean? Is there a famous namesake? Do you see those qualities in yourself?
Home district	Its three biggest problems? What would you do first as its DM? A recent news story from there?
Degree	Why leave your field? How can it help governance? A recent development in it?
Work experience	Why did you leave? What did you achieve? A key number from your own sector?
Optional subject	Why this optional? Which thinker do you disagree with? Is theory useful to a DM?
Service preference	Why this order? What if you get a lower preference? What does the service actually do?

CHAPTER 11

Situational Ethics

Situational questions test how you would act, not what you know. The board is looking for a sensible, lawful, humane officer, not a hero. Walk up the same six steps every time.

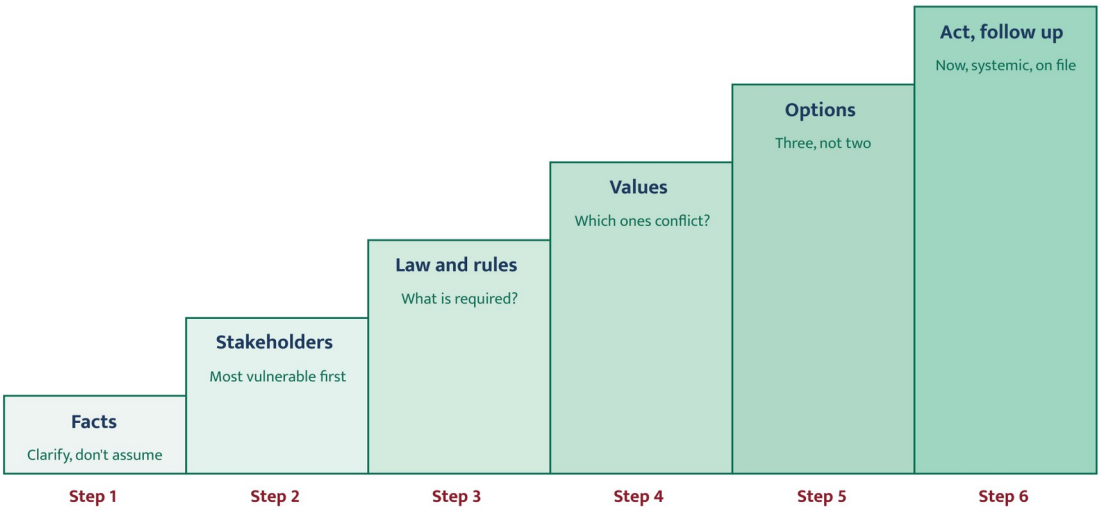


Figure 13. A six-step staircase for any situational question

Step 1. **Clarify the facts.** Don't assume the worst. Ask yourself, or the board, what you actually know.

Step 2. **Identify stakeholders.** Start with the most vulnerable person in the situation.

Step 3. **Check the law and rules.** The Constitution, the relevant Act, and the conduct rules for your service. Legality is the floor, not the ceiling.

Step 4. **Name the values in tension.** Integrity versus loyalty, compassion versus rules, speed versus due process.

Step 5. **Generate options.** List at least three. Binary choices such as “obey or resign” usually miss the practical middle path.

Step 6. **Act and follow up.** Give an immediate step, a systemic fix, and a record: a file note, a report, or an escalation through proper channels.

Traps to avoid

Heroic answers (“I would resign immediately”), passing the buck (“I would inform my senior and wait”), and rulebook rigidity that ignores the human cost. Each shows poor judgement.

Illustration: "Your senior asks you to sign a file you believe is wrong."

"First, Sir, I'd make sure I understand the file correctly, because I may be missing something. If I still find a problem, I'd respectfully explain it to my senior and suggest a lawful alternative. If I'm asked to proceed, I'd record my dissent on the file, which the system allows. If it's clearly illegal, I would not sign it, and I'd raise it through proper channels, while keeping the relationship professional. Separately, I'd suggest a clearer procedure so the same issue doesn't recur."

CHAPTER 12

Your Optional Subject

Whatever your optional, the board rarely tests it like an examiner. It tests whether your subject has helped you understand India. The same bridge applies to every optional: a concept or thinker, an Indian example, a reform or policy, a criticism, and your own view. This chapter takes Public Administration first, then Anthropology, Sociology, Geography and Political Science & International Relations.

Public Administration

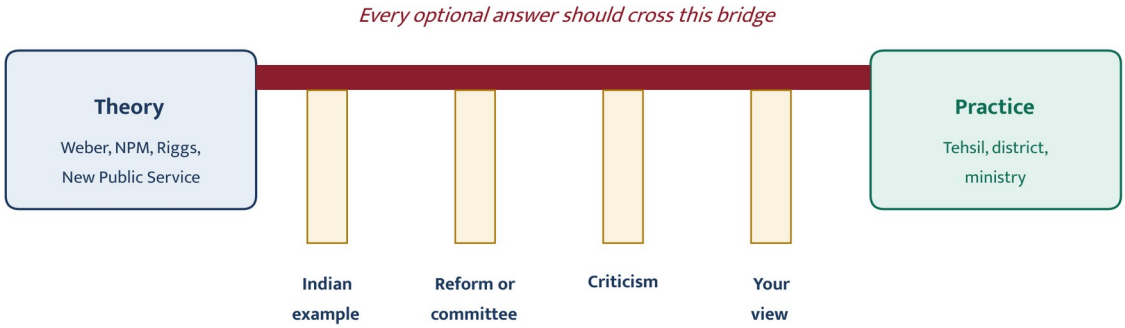


Figure 14. The bridge from theory to practice

Step 1. **Prepare an honest "why Public Administration" answer.** Link it to your story and your wish to understand how the state works.

Step 2. **Pair each thinker with an Indian example.** Weber with the tehsil office, NPM with outsourcing and PPPs, New Public Service with citizen charters, Riggs with prismatic features in Indian administration.

Step 3. **Link to live reforms.** Mission Karmayogi and iGOT, lateral entry, 2nd ARC recommendations, performance appraisal through APAR, RTI, and public services guarantee acts.

Step 4. **Know the criticisms.** For every reform, know one strong criticism and one sensible response.

Step 5. **Respect the practitioner.** A board member may have run a district or a ministry. Offer theory as a lens on their experience, never as a lecture.

Likely question	A useful angle
Is Weberian bureaucracy outdated?	Incomplete rather than outdated; keep accountability, add responsiveness.
Does lateral entry weaken the permanent civil service?	Useful for specialist roles; needs transparency, reservation clarity and accountability.
Can Mission Karmayogi change behaviour, not just skills?	Only if linked to appraisal, postings and leadership culture.
Are PPPs good for social sectors?	Depends on the model and regulation; tension with rights-based entitlements.
Is performance appraisal in India fair?	Discuss APAR transparency and the Dev Dutt case on communicating entries.
Who should appoint Information Commissioners?	Know the selection committee under the RTI Act and the debate on its balance.

From a real 2025 board

A Public Administration candidate on the Dinesh Dasa board (December 2025) was asked about the role of dissent in a democracy, Supreme Court dissents that later became law, and who sits on the committee that appoints Information Commissioners. Theory, constitutional history and a live institution, in three questions.

Anthropology

Anthropology candidates are expected to bring a field-worker's empathy to questions on tribes, culture and development. The board looks for respect for communities, without romanticising them or treating them as problems to be fixed.

Concept or thinker	Bridge to India
Functionalism (Malinowski)	Why customs persist: a tribal institution often meets a real need before it looks irrational to outsiders.
Isolation, assimilation, integration (Verrier Elwin, Nehru's Panchsheel)	The Fifth and Sixth Schedules, PESA 1996 and the Forest Rights Act 2006 as attempts at integration with autonomy.
Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)	75 PVTGs; PM-JANMAN (2023) for housing, roads, health and education in PVTG habitations.
Culture and ecology	Human–wildlife conflict, sacred groves, and traditional festivals such as Jallikattu: culture, animal welfare and law in tension.
Tribal health and nutrition	Sickle cell disease, anaemia and the National Sickle Cell Anaemia Elimination Mission (2023).

Likely question	A useful angle
Should tribal customs be preserved or reformed?	Preserve identity and autonomy; reform practices that violate rights, led from within the community.
Why is the Forest Rights Act poorly implemented?	Rejected claims, weak gram sabha capacity, and community forest rights lagging behind individual claims.

Likely question	A useful angle
Who should decide on inclusion in the ST list?	A transparent, evidence-based process; avoid political pressure diluting benefits for the most marginal.
Is development displacing tribals?	Free, prior and informed consent through gram sabhas; benefit-sharing, not just compensation.
Is anthropology useful for a DM?	Listening before acting; understanding a community's logic makes schemes work.

> **From real 2025 boards**
>
> Two Anthropology candidates (Lt Gen Raj Shukla and Sujata Chaturvedi boards) were barely asked about the optional itself. Instead they faced Kudumbashree, whether to ban Jallikattu as SDM, animal rights, why SHGs are mostly women's groups, and mother-tongue education. The lens of the optional, not its syllabus, is what gets tested.

Sociology

Sociology candidates should expect questions on caste, family, gender, religion and social change, often framed as debates. The board wants an evidence-based view that avoids both denial and outrage.

Concept or thinker	Bridge to India
Sanskritisation and dominant caste (M.N. Srinivas)	Caste mobility, demands for reservation by dominant castes, and the debate on a caste census.
Anomie (Durkheim)	Rapid urbanisation, migration and loneliness; student stress and suicides in coaching hubs.
Patriarchy and gender roles	Low female labour-force participation, dowry despite the law, and women's SHGs as a route to agency.
Changing family	Decline of the joint family, elder care, and the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act.
Social movements	From the Chipko and Dalit movements to digital campaigns: how social change is organised today.

Likely question	A useful angle
Is caste weakening in India?	Weakening in ritual and occupation, persisting in marriage, politics and networks; evidence on both sides.
Should there be a caste census?	Better data for policy versus fears of hardening identities; the design and use of data matter most.
Why does dowry persist despite the law?	Social norms outrun legal change; enforcement plus economic independence for women.
Is social media good for social cohesion?	Connects and mobilises, but also polarises; digital literacy and platform accountability.
How would sociology help you as a DM?	Seeing the social structure behind a problem, such as who is excluded and why.

Geography

Geography candidates are tested on how places shape lives: disasters, water, cities and borders. Strong answers connect a physical process to a human outcome and an administrative response.

Concept	Bridge to India
Himalayan fragility	Joshimath land subsidence (2023), the Wayanad landslides (2024) and the case for carrying-capacity studies.
Monsoon variability and climate change	Heatwaves, urban floods and Heat Action Plans; crop insurance and contingency plans.
Water resources	Groundwater depletion, river-linking such as the Ken–Betwa project, and Atal Bhujal Yojana.
Urban geography	Unplanned peri-urban growth, drainage and the need for metropolitan planning committees.
Geopolitics and location	How geography shapes strategy: chokepoints, the Indian Ocean, and inland waterways for logistics.

Likely question	A useful angle
Is geography destiny?	Geography sets constraints and opportunities; institutions decide outcomes (compare coastal and landlocked regions).
Why do Indian cities flood every year?	Encroached drains and wetlands, impervious surfaces, poor coordination; nature-based solutions.
Should rivers be interlinked?	Water security versus ecological, displacement and inter-state concerns; case-by-case appraisal.
Why are inland waterways underused?	Seasonal depth, dredging costs, poor last-mile links; potential for cheap cargo.
As DM of a flood-prone district, your first steps?	Risk maps, early warning, shelters, and pre-positioned supplies before the monsoon.

> **From a real 2025 board**
>
> A Geography candidate on the Anuradha Prasad board was asked whether History or Geography matters more, whether today's geopolitics is shaped by geography, and about the matchstick industry of his home district as SDM. Expect your optional to be used as a way to read current events.

Political Science and International Relations

PSIR is one of the most common optionals, and boards push PSIR candidates hard on current geopolitics and political theory. Balance and clarity matter more than names of theorists.

Concept or thinker	Bridge to India
Social contract (Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau)	Is the Constitution a social contract? Rights and duties, and the State's obligations to citizens.
Kautilya's Mandala theory	India's neighbourhood and great-power relations; where the theory fits and where it does not.
Realism and liberalism	Strategic autonomy and multi-alignment: working with the US, Russia and others at once.

Concept or thinker	Bridge to India
Ambedkar and constitutional morality	Dissent, institutions and the limits of majority rule.
Global South and multilateralism	UNSC reform, India's G20 presidency and the voice of developing countries.

Likely question	A useful angle
Should India comply with US demands on sanctions?	National interest and strategic autonomy; engage, but decide on energy and security needs independently.
Is the United States a declining power?	Relative change, not collapse; implications for a multipolar order and for India's partnerships.
Will India get a permanent UNSC seat?	Strong case, slow reform; build support through the Global South and coalitions.
Is India's neighbourhood policy working?	Successes in connectivity and aid; recurring trust deficits; the need for patient, people-centred ties.
Does democracy hurt the economy?	Slower decisions but more legitimacy and stability; evidence from long-run growth.

From real 2025 boards

PSIR candidates on the Sanjay Verma, Sheel Vardhan Singh and Suman Sharma boards were asked: is the Constitution a social contract; permanent versus elected executive; is the US declining; UNSC reform; India and the Global South; and whether India should follow US demands on sanctions. Shakti Dubey (AIR 1, 2024, PSIR) was asked to apply the Mandala theory to India's relations with China and Nepal.

CHAPTER 13

Current Developments

You cannot know everything, and the board does not expect you to. It expects you to have a considered view on the big issues and a clear view on the ones close to your DAF.

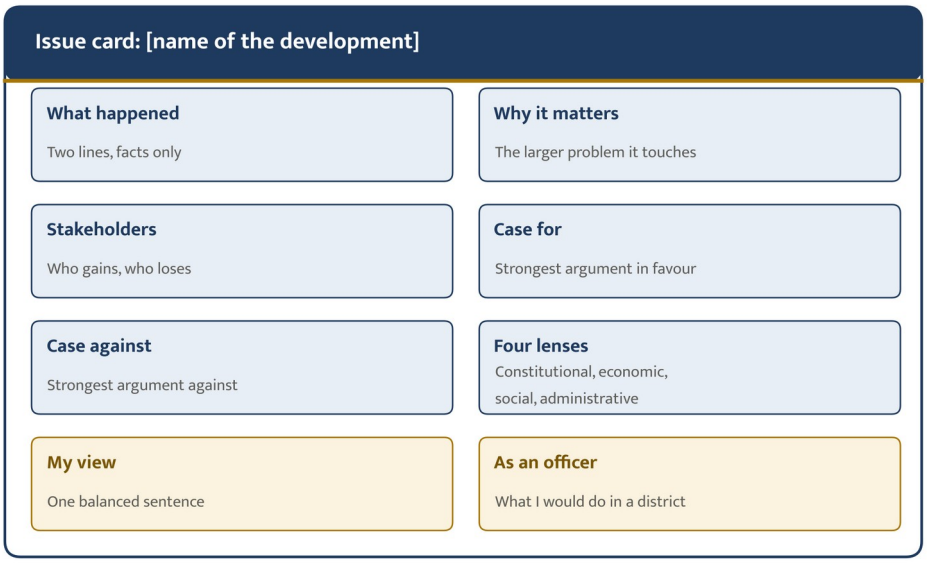


Figure 15. An issue card: one per major development

Step 1. **Set the window.** Study the last six to eight months intensively, and keep the year's biggest themes in view.

Step 2. **Filter by relevance.** Prioritise your state and district, your degree and work, your optional and hobbies, then major national and international issues.

Step 3. **Build an issue card for each.** Use the template above: facts, significance, stakeholders, both sides, four lenses, your view and your role as an officer.

Step 4. **Speak, don't just read.** Explain two issue cards aloud every day in under a minute each.

Step 5. **Stay neutral on contested politics.** Attribute claims ("the government argues… critics say…") and root your own view in the Constitution and evidence.

Step 6. **Revise monthly.** Convert your monthly current-affairs compendium into issue cards, so revision builds views rather than just facts.

Illustration: turning a news item into an interview answer

Development: The Supreme Court's Article 142 order in the NEET-UG 2026 paper-leak matter.

Possible questions: Should the Court use Article 142 so widely? How would you make an examination system leak-proof? Who is accountable when a national exam fails?

Balanced view: *"Article 142 exists to do complete justice, and when lakhs of students are affected, intervention is understandable. The longer-term answer is administrative, not judicial: secure supply chains for papers, technology with audit trails, strict enforcement of the anti-unfair-means law, and clear accountability for the conducting agency."*

Seven pillars at a glance

Pillar	What the board reads from it	One daily drill
Composure	Temperament under pressure	One interruption drill with a friend; note your recovery
Articulation	Clarity of thought	Record one 60-second answer; count fillers
Consistency	Credibility	Answer one issue in three framings; compare

Pillar	What the board reads from it	One daily drill
DAF dissection	Self-awareness and depth	Drill one DAF entry through six layers
Situational ethics	Judgement and integrity	Walk one dilemma up the six-step staircase
Optional	Theory meeting reality	Cross one thinker over the bridge to an Indian example
Current developments	Balance and awareness	Speak two issue cards aloud

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PART III

Inside the Board Room

What real boards asked in 2025–26

CHAPTER 14

Ten Real Boards of CSE 2025

The CSE 2025 Personality Tests ran from December 2025 into early 2026. Below are ten interviews across nine boards, reconstructed from transcripts that candidates shared after their interviews. They are candidates' own recollections, so treat details as approximate. Questions are paraphrased, and candidates are not named.

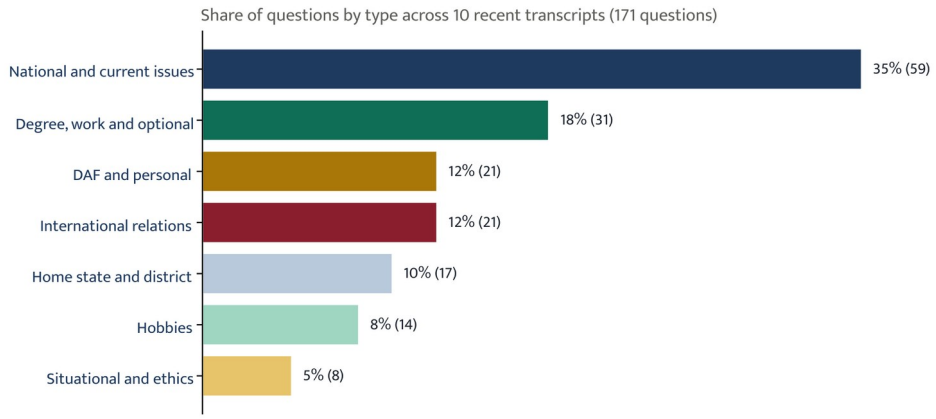


Figure 16. How the 171 questions in these ten transcripts were spread (author's classification, approximate)

Two things stand out. First, current and national issues make up about a third of all questions, but they are almost always reached **through** the DAF: a film leads to coastal security, a job leads to its sector's numbers. Second, purely situational questions are few, yet nearly every board had at least one "as DM, what would you do?" moment.

The ten boards

1. Dinesh Dasa Board • 16 Dec 2025 • Public Administration optional, Uttarakhand

Chairman: pressure of pilgrim footfall on Haridwar; who selects Information Commissioners; the role of dissent in democracy; Supreme Court dissents that later became law.

Members: infrastructure versus environment in Uttarakhand and whether EIAs are done properly; a minister pushing a highway despite an adverse EIA; the falling rupee despite growth; DM with limited funds, upgrade a hospital or build a new one; CAFE fuel-efficiency norms; what replaced Five-Year Plans; Article 370; Ambedkar's contributions.

Lesson: Home-state development, a live institution and two ministerial-pressure dilemmas in one interview. Members helped when the candidate did not know.

2. Sheel Vardhan Singh Board • 18 Dec 2025 • Doctor, PSIR optional

Chairman: have you been to rural India; anxieties of rural youth; three skills you would give

them; is the demographic dividend turning into a burden?

Members: health problems of farmers in intensive agriculture; is the US a declining power, can India become a superpower; recent trends in Indian politics, which led into women as voters and in planning; heading a project where a major mistake happens; why South Indian films are doing well; the craze for government jobs.

Lesson: The candidate described it as a round-table conversation. One remark about women voters set the direction for a whole member's questioning: what you say opens the next door.

3. Sanjay Verma Board • Jan 2026 • Civil engineer, PSIR optional, Bihar

Chairman: did you talk to others while waiting; web series versus films; is the Constitution a social contract; permanent versus elected executive.

Members: Vaishali's history; why bridges keep collapsing in Bihar; Venezuela and India; UNSC reform; NSS work on Swachh Bharat; solid waste management technologies; describe Madhubani painting and its colours; a recent film, which led to the 26/11 attacks and coastal security; why civil services after engineering; neighbourhood policy; why India held together when others broke up.

Lesson: Hobbies became gateways: a film led to national security, a painting style to culture. Prepare one step beyond every hobby.

4. Bidyut Behari Swain Board • Jan 2026 • Doctor, Hindi Literature optional

Chairman: do you only watch travel vlogs or actually travel; the last place you visited.

Members: what you did in four years since leaving residency; why Hindi Literature; favourite canto of Rashmirathi; India–US tariffs; semiconductor supply-chain alliances; why leave medicine; medical tourism; where public health money should go; violence against doctors; a custodial-death scenario as IPS officer; why India's neighbours are unstable.

Lesson: Former professionals are questioned hard on their own field. The candidate stumbled on two questions; a short “I'm not sure” would have served better than a long monologue.

5. Lt Gen Raj Shukla Board • 19 Jan 2026 • Electrical engineer, former R&D professional, Anthropology optional, Kerala

Chairman: why you left your job; R&D in India; name pure-R&D startups; R&D spending of global firms and of your former employer; why private R&D is low.

Members: why inland waterways are underdeveloped in Kerala; the North–South debate on population and delimitation; recent income-tax simplification; an example of improving your team's efficiency; replicating Kerala tourism; Kudumbashree; as SDM, would you ban Jallikattu?

Lesson: The clearest stress interview of the set: interruptions and an abrupt close, while other members stayed cordial. Know your own sector's numbers, and keep one concrete achievement from your job ready.

6. Sujata Chaturvedi Board • Jan 2026 • Physics graduate, Anthropology optional, Maharashtra

Chairman: explain the theory of relativity; which calendar system is behind the panel; Switzerland's neutrality and whether India could be neutral; why population alone does not make India powerful.

Members: what Nashik is known for; is 50% GER achievable; identify a painting shown to you; define creativity; famous Indian flautists (the candidate's hobby); why India did not sign the NPT; rare earths; why SHGs are mostly women's groups; mother-tongue education; the “God particle” and quantum technology.

Lesson: Expect basics of your own degree explained simply, and even props in the room. Breadth of curiosity was being tested.

7. Dinesh Dasa Board • 20 Jan 2026 • Zoology optional, Kerala

Chairman: your biggest inspiration; is reflective walking just an aspirant's hobby?

Members: should India rejoin RCEP; human–wildlife conflict as DM of Wayanad; invasive forest species; which state has a “money-order economy”; can dance teach empathy; are prisons a waste of taxpayers' money; Satyagraha; military or civil service; compare a Kerala village with the Delhi village where you ran a health camp.

Lesson: A light exchange at the greeting set a warm tone. Unusual hobbies invite a challenge: be ready to show they are real.

8. Anuradha Prasad Board • 21 Jan 2026 • Working professional (IT, insurance PSU), Geography optional, Tamil Nadu

Chairman: your name combines two deities, do you see their traits in yourself; your NSS work with Chennai Metro; history of the Railways; will AI replace entry-level jobs?

Members: bio-methane; GPS; Space Policy 2023; Mahabalipuram; does geography shape geopolitics; your employer's solvency ratio; would you accept privatisation of your PSU; universal insurance by 2047; downsides of ODF status; labour laws for the matchstick industry in your district as SDM; the three-language debate.

Lesson: The path ran name → job → employer's data → district industry. Every DAF line was used.

9. Suman Sharma Board • 21 Jan 2026 • Law graduate, Law optional, Maharashtra

Chairperson: landmark judgments; why the electoral bonds scheme was struck down; should judges be appointed on contract; does democracy hurt the economy, argue both sides.

Members: has BNSS reduced pendency; One Nation One Subscription; Vadhavan port; a girl crying alone at a railway station, what do you do; free legal aid as DM; technocratic governance; militarisation of South Asia; how India should respond to US policy shifts; MoU versus

agreement; import dependence.

Lesson: Optional-heavy, then a sharp turn to a human situation at a railway station. Situational questions often arrive without warning.

10. Suman Sharma Board • 2 Feb 2026 • Commerce graduate, PSIR optional

Chairperson: Ponzi schemes versus multi-level marketing; the right approach to Pakistan; is India's future in the Global South?

Members: logistics; tribal development and Left Wing Extremism; UN reform and a permanent UNSC seat; should India leave WHO; SWAYAM and DIKSHA; progress on SDG-4 and SDG-5; regulating digital news and OTT platforms; should India follow US demands on sanctions?

Lesson: Questions tracked the DAF closely: student-media work led to media regulation, SDG interest to SDG progress.

Eight lessons from these ten boards

1. The DAF steers the interview; hobbies are probed for depth and for proof that they are real.

2. Former professionals face number-level questions about their own sector, and "why leave?" is near-certain.

3. Home district and state questions are built around development problems, not trivia.

4. Almost every board has one "as DM or SDM, what would you do?" question, often involving a minister's pressure or scarce funds.

5. Geopolitics was current and centred on the United States, with India's neighbourhood a close second.

6. Recent Acts, schemes and policies are tested directly; missing one is survivable if you say so cleanly.

7. Abstract debate questions ("Is the Constitution a social contract?") sit alongside facts.

8. Board temperament varies from warm to stressful; the same composure works for both.

Source: candidate-shared CSE 2025 interview transcripts compiled by ForumIAS.

CHAPTER 15

Toppers' Voices

Toppers rarely publish their full interviews, but the little they have said publicly is revealing. What follows draws only on their own words or on reports of their boards, in short excerpts.

Ranker	What they said or faced	The lesson
Anuj Agnihotri AIR 1, CSE 2025 Interview 204	"Anything can be asked in an interview." His board asked about his medical background and Rajasthan's history, including who Meerabai's guru was.	Prepare depth, then accept that surprises will come. Calm matters more than coverage.

Ranker	What they said or faced	The lesson
Shakti Dubey AIR 1, CSE 2024 Interview 200	Asked to apply the Mandala theory to India–China and India–Nepal ties, she found it hard and told the board, "this could be an exception." She was also asked to recite her own poetry, and about crowd management at the Mahakumbh.	Disagreeing respectfully with a framework, and admitting what you need to study further, did not stop the highest-scoring answer of her year.
Ettaboyina Sai Shivani AIR 11, CSE 2024 Interview 201	Asked why God does not come down now when there is so much injustice, she replied: "God does not need to arrive from somewhere else."	A philosophical question rewards a personal, values-based answer, not a lecture.
Aditya Srivastava AIR 1, CSE 2023	Comparing his final attempt with his previous one, he said he "performed better than the last time in the Mains and in the interview".	Every attempt can improve your interview. Treat earlier boards as feedback.
Aakash Garg AIR 5, CSE 2024 Interview 201	Reported to have been asked how his computer-science engineering would help in administration; he spoke of data-based decisions and simulation.	Translate your degree into an administrator's tool.

The highest interview scores of CSE 2025

Candidate	Rank	Interview marks (out of 275)
Tejaswini Singh	AIR 62	225
Anjana B	AIR 222	220
Anita Deora	AIR 644	220
Saurabh Sharma	AIR 146	218
Komal Mavi	AIR 314	216

Notice the ranks. The highest interview scorers were spread across the merit list, which means the interview rewards personality, not rank-level knowledge. A strong Personality Test is within reach of every candidate who reaches Dholpur House.

> **What these voices have in common**
>
> **Honesty** about difficulty (Shakti Dubey, Anuj Agnihotri) • **values** in philosophical answers (Sai Shivani) • **improvement** across attempts (Aditya Srivastava) • **translation** of one's background into administration (Aakash Garg).

Sources: reports in Asianet News, ETV Bharat, ThePrint, DNA, ap7am and Indian Masterminds; marks as published by UPSC and reported by Drishti IAS and PTI.

CHAPTER 16

DAF Profiles by Background

Your background decides much of the first ten minutes. Here are question sets for five common profiles. Use the one closest to you, then rewrite it with your own details.

Engineer (any branch)

1. Why leave engineering after a good college?

2. Explain a core concept of your branch to a layperson.
3. How can your branch help a district administration?
4. Why do bridges and buildings fail in India: design, material or governance?
5. Is India's R&D spending adequate? Why is private R&D low?
6. Semiconductors: where does India stand?
7. Should engineers be posted in technical ministries rather than general administration?
8. AI and automation: threat or opportunity for jobs?
9. Which infrastructure project in your state would you fast-track?
10. An engineering ethics case: a contractor offers to cut corners. What do you do as DM?
11. Your final-year project: what did it teach you about teamwork?
12. Smart Cities Mission: success or not?
13. Electric vehicles: is India's charging infrastructure ready?
14. Solid waste management: one technology you would introduce.
15. How would you use GIS or drones in land records?

Doctor

1. Why leave medicine when the country needs doctors?
2. Out-of-pocket health spending: why so high, and what would you change?
3. Violence against doctors: causes and remedies.
4. Primary versus tertiary care: where should the next rupee go?
5. Medical tourism: opportunity or distraction?
6. Non-communicable diseases in your state: two numbers and two actions.
7. Ayushman Bharat: what is working, what is not?
8. Should rural service be compulsory for MBBS graduates?
9. Antimicrobial resistance: what can a DM do?
10. Mental health in your district: how would you start?
11. A health-camp or internship moment that changed your thinking.
12. What skills from medicine will help you in administration?
13. Nutrition and stunting: one district-level intervention.
14. Should AI be allowed to make diagnostic decisions?
15. An epidemic breaks out in your district: your first 48 hours.

Humanities or social science graduate

1. How has your subject shaped how you see India?
2. A thinker from your subject you disagree with, and why.
3. Is history being rewritten? How should a civil servant respond?
4. Caste census: arguments for and against.
5. Is India becoming more or less unequal?
6. Mother-tongue education: strengths and limits.
7. What can literature teach an administrator?
8. Explain a concept from your degree using your district as an example.
9. Is the Constitution a social contract?
10. Role of dissent in a democracy.
11. Migration from your state: push or pull factors?

12. Is urban India losing its heritage?
13. One reform you would make to school education.
14. Are social media and democracy compatible?
15. Which social movement in India inspires you?

Working professional or gap-year candidate

1. Why leave a stable job?
2. What exactly did you do, and one result you can measure?
3. A key number from your sector (for example, solvency ratio, attrition, margin).
4. Would you accept privatisation of your organisation?
5. What did your workplace teach you about systems and incentives?
6. A conflict at work and how you handled it.
7. Will AI replace entry-level jobs in your field?
8. What have you done in your gap years apart from studying?
9. Why should we not see the gap as a lack of direction?
10. How will your corporate experience help in government?
11. Is government too slow compared with the private sector? Why?
12. Lateral entry: good idea or not?
13. Your biggest professional failure.
14. What would you miss about your old job?
15. What will you do if you are not selected this time?

Public Administration optional

1. Why did you choose Public Administration?
2. Is Weberian bureaucracy outdated?
3. New Public Management: did it suit India?
4. Mission Karmayogi: can it change behaviour?
5. Lateral entry versus a permanent civil service.
6. Who selects Information Commissioners, and is the committee balanced?
7. Is RTI weakening or strengthening governance?
8. Role of dissent in democracy, and dissents that later became law.
9. Citizen charters: why have they not worked well?
10. Performance appraisal: is APAR fair?
11. 2nd ARC: one recommendation you would implement first.
12. Civil service neutrality versus commitment.
13. Riggs' prismatic society: is it visible in your district?
14. Good governance: how would you measure it?
15. Is decentralisation real in India's local bodies?

CHAPTER 17

Your Home State and District Profile

Boards love the home district because it reveals whether you have looked closely at the place that made you. In the ten 2025 transcripts, Haridwar's footfall, Tenkasi's matchstick industry, Kerala's backwaters and Bihar's bridges all came up. Prepare a one-page profile using this template.

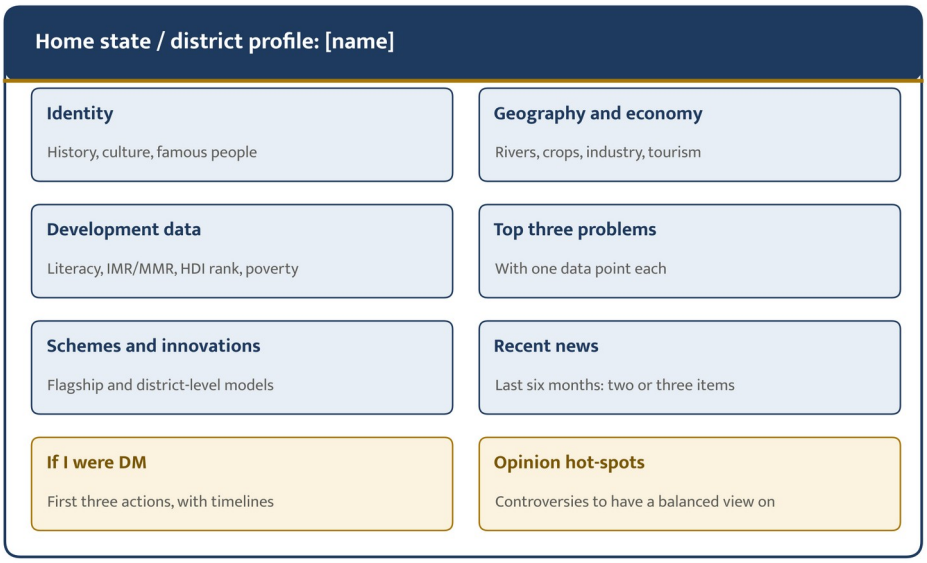


Figure 17. A one-page template for your home state or district

Step 1. **Collect the basics.** History, culture, famous people, rivers, crops, industries, tourism. Know why your district is famous, and what it was once famous for.

Step 2. **Get the development data.** Literacy, sex ratio, IMR and MMR, health and nutrition indicators, and the district's rank on any state or national index.

Step 3. **Name three problems with evidence.** One data point for each, from an official source.

Step 4. **Know the schemes and innovations.** Flagship schemes in the district, any award-winning local model, and the Aspirational District status if it applies.

Step 5. **Scan the last six months.** Two or three news items: a disaster, a project, a controversy, an achievement.

Step 6. **Plan as DM.** Your first three actions, with a timeline and who you would involve.

Where to find reliable data

Census District Census Handbooks • NFHS-5 district fact sheets • the state's Economic Survey • the district's official website (nic.in) • NITI Aayog's Aspirational Districts dashboard • the state SDG index report.

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PART IV
Ready Reckoner

For the final weeks

CHAPTER 18
The Last 48 Hours and the Day Itself

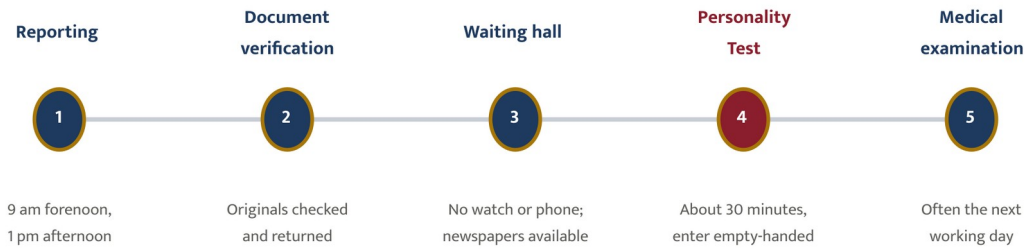


Figure 18. A typical interview day at Dholpur House

For the CSE 2024 cycle, reporting times were 9 am for the forenoon session and 1 pm for the afternoon session. Check your own e-summons, as details can change. Your original documents are verified and usually returned before the interview. Watches are not allowed in the hall, phones are best left outside, and newspapers are usually available while you wait. You enter the interview room empty-handed. If your interview is on a Friday, the medical examination may only happen on the next working day, so plan your stay.

> **Document checklist**
>
> e-Summons letter • originals and self-attested copies of age, educational and other certificates listed in the summons • category, EWS or PwBD certificates if applicable • photographs as specified • TA claim form if you are an outstation candidate.

In the final two days, stop learning. Revise your DAF story, read the newspaper, sleep properly, and walk in with gratitude rather than fear. You have already done what 99% of applicants could not.

In the room, treat every member as a senior colleague who is curious about you, not an examiner hunting for faults. When the chairperson says “Thank you”, smile, thank the board, and leave without searching faces for your marks.

CHAPTER 19
Expected Question Bank

Answer each question aloud in the four-beat rhythm, record yourself, and then build your own version from your DAF. Model answers to all 31 questions are in Part V.

Personal and DAF-based

1. Tell us about yourself.

2. What does your name mean?
3. Why civil services? Why not continue in your profession?
4. Why is your first service preference what it is?
5. What are your strengths and weaknesses? Give an example of each.
6. Why did you choose your optional subject?
7. What have you done in your gap year or years?
8. What are the three major problems of your district, and how would you solve them as DM?

Hobby-based

1. How has your hobby shaped your personality?
2. Who is the greatest figure in your hobby area, and why?
3. How can your hobby help you as an administrator?

Current affairs and opinion

1. How should India respond to border tensions with neighbouring countries?
2. How should India balance economic development and environmental conservation?
3. What measures would you suggest to deal with corruption in India?
4. Which recent government reform or policy stood out to you?
5. Should AI be regulated? How should India approach it?
6. Is India's demographic dividend turning into a demographic burden?
7. Is federalism in India under strain?

Situational and ethics

1. A politician pressures you to transfer an honest officer. What do you do?
2. As SP, a communal riot breaks out and your own community is involved. How do you act?
3. Your senior asks you to sign a file you believe is wrong. What do you do?
4. How would you handle a protest against a development project in your district?
5. Would you prefer a home-state posting or a conflict-prone border district?

Philosophical

1. What is the difference between leadership and management?
2. Is honesty enough for a civil servant?
3. Should a civil servant prize intelligence or wisdom?
4. What will India look like in 2047, and what is your role in it?

Public Administration optional

1. Is bureaucracy a hindrance to development?
2. How do you define good governance?
3. Would you favour lateral entry or permanent civil servants?
4. Does RTI help or hamper administration?

CHAPTER 20

Do's and Don'ts

✓ Do	× Don't
Greet the board politely and wait to be asked before you sit	Walk in hurriedly or sit without being asked
Keep answers short and structured, about 30–60 seconds	Give long lectures or speeches
Say "I'm not aware, Sir/Ma'am" when you don't know	Bluff or guess wildly
Make eye contact with the whole board, especially the questioner	Stare at one member or look at the floor
Give balanced, constitutional, solution-oriented views	Take extreme, partisan or communal positions
Accept a mistake gracefully if the board corrects you	Argue or get defensive
Answer stress questions calmly, even with a smile	Show irritation, nervousness or arrogance
Link your answers to the role of an administrator	Criticise the government, the board or UPSC
Be honest about weaknesses, with how you are improving	Claim you have no weaknesses
Know your DAF thoroughly	Contradict what you wrote in the DAF
Keep your posture upright and your hands still	Fidget, cross your arms or lean back
Thank the board at the end	Ask how you performed

A mentor's last word

The board is not looking for a perfect candidate. It is looking for an honest, balanced, calm person who would be kind to a citizen standing nervously at their office door. If you become that person in the next six weeks, the interview will simply show it.

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Ecology & Env.	04
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PART V

Model Answers

31 expected questions, answered

These are not scripts to memorise. A memorised answer sounds memorised, and boards notice within seconds. Read each answer to see its **shape**: a clear position, a reason, the other side, and what you would do as an officer. Then rebuild it in your own words, from your own life.

Answers to personal questions use one illustrative candidate, so that you can see how a real profile turns into real answers. Replace every detail with your own.

The illustrative candidate

Background: civil engineering graduate from Jhansi district, Uttar Pradesh (Bundelkhand); worked two years as a site engineer on rural road projects.

Optional: Public Administration. **Hobby:** kitchen gardening. **Service preference:** IAS first.

Name used in examples: Pranav.

Each answer has four parts

What the board is testing — the quality behind the question.

Model answer — spoken length, in the four-beat rhythm where it fits.

Likely follow-ups — where the board may go next.

Avoid — the most common way candidates lose marks on that question.

SECTION A

Personal and DAF-Based Questions

Q1. Tell us about yourself.

What the board is testing: *Self-awareness, structure, and whether you can be brief.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, I'm Pranav, from Jhansi in Bundelkhand, a region where water decides almost everything, from crops to migration. I studied civil engineering and then spent two years building rural roads. That work showed me that a road is not just asphalt; it decides whether a pregnant woman reaches a hospital in time.

That is what pulled me towards administration. I chose Public Administration as my optional to understand why good schemes often fail at the last mile. Outside work, I grow vegetables on my terrace, which has taught me patience and some respect for soil and water. I'd describe myself as practical, a good listener, and still learning to say no."

Likely follow-ups

- Tell us more about the roads you built. What went wrong?
- Why do you call yourself a good listener? Give an example.
- What does "learning to say no" mean for an officer?

Avoid: Reciting your DAF line by line, or starting with your date of birth. Choose three threads that connect into one story.

Q2. What does your name mean?

What the board is testing: *Composure on an easy opener, and whether you can make a small question interesting.*

> **Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)**
>
> "Pranav means the sacred syllable Om, Sir, the sound that, in Indian thought, contains everything. My grandmother chose it. I can't claim to live up to it, but I like one idea in it: that a small, steady sound can hold a lot. I think administration is a bit like that. Small, consistent actions, done every day, add up to big change."

Likely follow-ups

- Are you religious?
- Do you think names shape personality?
- Who else is known by this name?

Avoid: Giving only a one-word meaning and stopping. Add one personal or reflective line, but keep it short.

Q3. Why civil services? Why not continue in engineering?

What the board is testing: *Genuine motivation, and whether you respect your earlier profession.*

> **Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)**
>
> "Sir, I haven't left engineering behind; I want to use it at a larger scale. **Position.**
>
> As a site engineer I could build a good road, but I couldn't decide where roads were needed, fix land disputes, or make sure the contractor was paid on time so work didn't stop. Those decisions sat with the administration. **Reason.**
>
> Engineering is honourable work, and the country needs good engineers; I'm not escaping it. **Other side.**
>
> As a district officer, my engineering training would help me read estimates, check quality and use GIS for planning, while the service gives me the reach to fix the system around the road, not just the road. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- If you don't get IAS, will you go back to engineering?
- How would you check the quality of a road as DM?
- Isn't this a waste of public money spent on your engineering education?

Avoid: Saying "to serve the nation" without a personal story, or speaking dismissively of your old field.

Q4. Why is IAS your first preference?

What the board is testing: *Clarity about what the services actually do, and maturity about outcomes.*

> **Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)**
>
> "Sir, the IAS gives the widest view of governance, from a block to a ministry, and my strongest motivation came from district-level problems like water, roads and land records. That is the work I feel prepared for.
>
> I know every service has its own value. The IPS protects the conditions in which development is

possible, and the foreign service represents India's interests abroad. If I'm allotted another service, I'll give it the same commitment, because the purpose, public service, stays the same."

Likely follow-ups

- What does an IAS officer do in the first five years?
- Why not IPS, with your field background?
- Which cadre would you prefer, and why?

Avoid: Running down other services, or sounding as if you'd be disappointed with anything else.

Q5. What are your strengths and weaknesses?

What the board is testing: *Self-awareness, honesty and evidence.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, one strength is that I stay calm on the ground. On a road site, when villagers stopped work over a drainage dispute, I sat with them, walked the stretch together, and we redesigned one culvert. Work resumed in two days.

A weakness is that I find it hard to delegate; I like to check everything myself. That slowed my team once. I'm working on it by setting clear checkpoints instead of supervising every step, and it has helped."

Likely follow-ups

- How will that weakness show up as an SDM?
- Give another example of staying calm.
- What would your former supervisor say about you?

Avoid: Disguised strengths as weaknesses ("I work too hard"). Boards see through it immediately.

Q6. Why did you choose Public Administration as your optional?

What the board is testing: *Authenticity and intellectual curiosity.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, on rural road projects I kept seeing good schemes slowed by files, approvals and unclear responsibility. Public Administration gave me a vocabulary for what I was seeing: Weber helped me see why rules exist, and the critics helped me see why they can fail citizens.

It also connects directly with the work I hope to do. When I read about public services guarantee acts or Mission Karmayogi, I can picture where they would matter in a district office."

Likely follow-ups

- Which thinker do you disagree with most?
- Is Public Administration a science?
- How would Riggs describe your district?

Avoid: Saying you chose it because it is "scoring" or "overlaps with GS". Even if true, it is not the whole story.

Q7. What have you done in your gap years?

What the board is testing: *Honesty, productive use of time and resilience.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, mostly I prepared for this examination, and I won't pretend otherwise. Alongside, I taught mathematics twice a week to children from a nearby basti, which kept me grounded, and I kept up my terrace garden, which became a small experiment in composting and water use.

> The years taught me patience and how to handle failure without becoming bitter. I think those will matter in a career where many things will not go as planned."

Likely follow-ups

- What did the children teach you?
- How did you handle the failures?
- What will you do if you're not selected?

Avoid: Inventing activities you cannot discuss in depth, or sounding apologetic about the gap.

Q8. What are the three major problems of your district, and how would you solve them as DM?

What the board is testing: *Grounded knowledge of your home district and a practical, prioritised plan.*

> **Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)**
>
> "Sir, in Jhansi I'd name three: water scarcity and recurring drought, distress migration of young men, and weak last-mile health care in rural blocks.
>
> On water, I'd make farm ponds and check-dams a convergence priority under MGNREGA and the watershed programmes, and push micro-irrigation. On migration, I'd link skill training to the industrial and defence-corridor jobs being created in the region, so training leads to employment. On health, I'd fix staffing and referral transport at PHCs first, because a well-run PHC is more valuable than a new building.
>
> I'd also set three measurable targets and review them every month, so the plan doesn't stay on paper."

Likely follow-ups

- How will the Ken–Betwa link project affect Bundelkhand?
- Why has migration persisted despite schemes?
- What would you do in your first week as DM?

Avoid: Listing problems with no data, or offering solutions that are just names of schemes.

SECTION B

Hobby-Based Questions

Q9. How has your hobby shaped your personality?

What the board is testing: *Whether the hobby is real, and whether you can reflect on it.*

> **Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)**
>
> "Sir, kitchen gardening has taught me patience, because nothing grows faster when you worry about it. It has also taught me to observe: yellowing leaves usually mean a problem in the soil or water, not the leaf itself.
>
> I think that's a useful habit for an administrator. When a scheme fails, the visible symptom is rarely the real cause. You have to look at the soil of the system, the incentives, the staff, the funding, before you treat the leaves."

Likely follow-ups

- What are you growing at the moment?
- What is composting, and how do you do it?
- Could kitchen gardens help with nutrition in your district?

Avoid: Listing a hobby you haven't practised for years. Boards often ask what you did last week.

Q10. Who is the greatest figure in your hobby area, and why?

What the board is testing: *Depth of interest beyond the surface.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, for me it would be Subhash Palekar, who popularised zero-budget natural farming in India. I don't agree with everything in his approach, and scientists have raised questions about yields at scale, but he made millions of farmers think about soil health and input costs.

What I admire is the shift in thinking: treating soil as something living rather than a medium to pour chemicals into. My terrace garden is a very small version of that idea."

Likely follow-ups

- What are the criticisms of natural farming?
- What did Andhra Pradesh do with natural farming?
- Should India move fully to organic farming?

Avoid: Naming a famous figure without knowing why they matter, or sounding uncritical.

Q11. How can your hobby help you as an administrator?

What the board is testing: *Translating personal interest into public value.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"In two ways, Sir. Practically, I understand composting and small-scale water use, which helps when discussing solid waste management or nutrition gardens in schools and anganwadis.

More importantly, it keeps me patient and observant. An administrator often has to wait for results while keeping a close eye on early signs. Gardening trains exactly that."

Likely follow-ups

- How would you start school nutrition gardens in your district?
- What is the PM POSHAN scheme?
- How would you reduce wet waste in a town?

Avoid: Over-claiming that your hobby will transform governance.

SECTION C

Current Affairs and Opinion

Q12. How should India respond to border tensions with neighbouring countries?

What the board is testing: *Balance, strategic maturity and avoiding jingoism.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, firmly on security and patiently on diplomacy. **Position.**

Territorial integrity is not negotiable, so India has rightly strengthened border infrastructure, surveillance and military readiness. At the same time, talks through military and diplomatic channels have helped reduce friction and manage disengagement. **Reason.**

Some argue that talking signals weakness; others that strength provokes escalation. Experience suggests India needs both: deterrence makes diplomacy credible. **Other side.**

For a civil servant, the less visible part matters too: better roads, connectivity and livelihoods in border villages, as the Vibrant Villages Programme attempts, so that border communities are stakeholders in security. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- Should India trade with a country it has border disputes with?
- What is the Vibrant Villages Programme?
- What role do states play in border management?

Avoid: Emotional or aggressive language, or naming blame in a way that sounds partisan.

Q13. How should India balance economic development and environmental conservation?

What the board is testing: *Balance of judgement and use of evidence.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, I don't see them as opposites; the real question is how we develop. **Position.**

India still needs growth for jobs and infrastructure, but climate change, air pollution and water stress are already imposing economic costs, especially on the poor. **Reason.**

There are genuine trade-offs, for example in mining or large dams, where communities and forests bear costs while benefits go elsewhere. **Other side.**

As an officer, I'd insist on honest environmental impact assessment, real public hearings, compensatory measures that actually happen on the ground, and choosing lower-impact designs early, when changes are cheapest. India's net-zero target for 2070 and Mission LiFE show the direction; the district is where it becomes real. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- A minister wants a highway despite an adverse EIA. What do you do?
- Are EIAs done properly in India?
- Should coal be phased out?

Avoid: A generic "sustainable development is the answer" with no example of how.

Q14. What measures would you suggest to deal with corruption in India?

What the board is testing: *Integrity, systems thinking and realism.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, I'd focus on reducing discretion and increasing transparency, rather than relying only on punishment. **Position.**

Direct benefit transfers, online land records and e-procurement have already reduced opportunities for petty corruption, because they remove the face-to-face moment where money changes hands. **Reason.**

Technology is not enough on its own; corruption shifts to new points, and laws like the Lokpal Act need strong, independent institutions to work. **Other side.**

As a district officer, I'd publish timelines for services, use social audits, protect whistle-blowers in my own office, and lead by example, because a team watches what its head actually does. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- What changed in the Prevention of Corruption Act in 2018?
- Why hasn't the Lokpal been more effective?
- Your own office clerk asks a citizen for money. What do you do?

Avoid: Moralising ("people must become honest") without any system-level measures.

Q15. Which recent government reform or policy stood out to you?

What the board is testing: *Awareness, analysis, and the ability to see both sides of your own choice.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, I'd choose Mission Karmayogi, the capacity-building reform for civil servants. **Position.**

It moves training from a one-time event to continuous, role-based learning through the iGOT platform, which matters because the skills a district officer needs keep changing, from disaster management to data. **Reason.**

The risk is that it becomes a box-ticking exercise of online courses, without changing behaviour or how officers are posted and appraised. **Other side.**

If I join the service, I'd treat it as a real tool and suggest that training completion be linked to roles and reviewed in performance discussions, not just counted. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- What is the Capacity Building Commission?
- Is online training effective for field officers?
- How would you train your tehsil staff?

Avoid: Choosing a reform you cannot discuss critically, or praising it in a way that sounds political.

Q16. Should AI be regulated? How should India approach it?

What the board is testing: *Understanding of technology, and balance between innovation and rights.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Yes, Sir, but in proportion to risk. **Position.**

AI can help in diagnosis, crop advisories and grievance handling, but it can also produce biased decisions, deepfakes and privacy harms, especially when it is used in policing or welfare. **Reason.**

Heavy regulation too early could slow Indian innovation and startups, which is why India has so far preferred guidelines and sector-specific rules over a single sweeping law. **Other side.**

In government, I'd follow a simple rule: a human must remain accountable for any decision that affects a citizen's rights, data use must follow the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, and citizens should be able to know and challenge an AI-assisted decision. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- Would you use facial recognition for policing?
- What is the IndiaAI Mission?
- How would you use AI in a district office?

Avoid: Either fear of all technology or uncritical enthusiasm.

Q17. Is India's demographic dividend turning into a demographic burden?

What the board is testing: *Data-aware analysis, and constructive optimism.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Not yet, Sir, but the window is time-bound. **Position.**

India's working-age population is large and still growing, and the Economic Survey has projected that its share will peak around 2041. That is an opportunity only if young people are healthy, skilled and employed. **Reason.**

The worry is real: low female workforce participation, many young people in informal or low-

paid jobs, and a skills mismatch. A dividend not used becomes a burden. **Other side.**

At the district level, I'd focus on what can be measured: anaemia and nutrition in adolescents, girls' transition to secondary school, and skills linked to actual local employers, not just certificates. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- Why is women's workforce participation low?
- Will AI take away the jobs young people need?
- What does the North–South fertility gap mean for federalism?

Avoid: A one-sided "India is the youngest country, so the future is bright" answer.

Q18. Is federalism in India under strain?

What the board is testing: *Constitutional understanding and balanced political judgement.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"There are real tensions, Sir, but the system is also showing it can adapt. **Position.**

Disputes over the role of Governors, the divisible pool of taxes, cesses that states don't share, and the coming delimitation have all raised concerns among states. **Reason.**

At the same time, the GST Council is an example of states and the Centre deciding together, and many states have used cooperative mechanisms well. Strain is normal in a large federation; what matters is whether it is resolved through institutions. **Other side.**

As an All India Services officer, I'd serve the state and the Centre with equal loyalty to the Constitution, and I believe more regular use of the Inter-State Council would help settle disputes before they reach court. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- Should Governors have a fixed time to act on bills?
- What is the role of the Finance Commission?
- Is the GST Council truly cooperative?

Avoid: Taking sides between particular governments or parties.

SECTION D

Situational and Ethics Questions

Q19. A politician pressures you to transfer an honest officer. What do you do?

What the board is testing: *Integrity, tact and knowledge of rules.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, first I'd listen and ask for the reason, because there may be a genuine complaint I'm not aware of. If there is one, I'd look into it fairly.

If the request has no basis, I'd politely explain that transfers follow rules and a minimum tenure, and that moving an officer who is doing good work would hurt public service. I'd record the oral request in a file note, as the Supreme Court has encouraged in T.S.R. Subramanian, and inform my senior.

I would not transfer the officer without cause, but I'd stay respectful with the politician, because I will need to work with elected representatives for the district's benefit."

Likely follow-ups

- The politician threatens to have you transferred. What then?
- What if the officer actually has a bad reputation?
- Should civil servants be protected by fixed tenure?

Avoid: Heroic defiance that burns bridges, or simply saying "I would follow orders".

Q20. As SP, a communal riot breaks out and your own community is involved. How do you act?

What the board is testing: *Impartiality under maximum pressure.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, my uniform has no community. My first duty is to stop violence and protect lives, whoever they are.

Immediately, I'd deploy force at flashpoints, impose prohibitory orders if needed, and coordinate with the DM. I'd act on the basis of evidence and video, and arrest those who broke the law irrespective of community, and I'd make that visible so that trust in the police is not lost.

I'd bring in peace committees with respected leaders of all communities, counter rumours on social media quickly, and ensure relief and FIRs for victims. Later, I'd look at what intelligence we missed."

Likely follow-ups

- What if your relatives ask you for help?
- How do you counter rumours spreading online?
- What is the role of peace committees?

Avoid: Any hint of sympathy for one side, or vague answers without immediate operational steps.

Q21. Your senior asks you to sign a file you believe is wrong. What do you do?

What the board is testing: *Integrity with professionalism and knowledge of procedure.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, first I'd make sure I understand the file correctly, because I may be missing something. If I still find a problem, I'd respectfully explain it to my senior and suggest a lawful alternative.

If I'm asked to proceed and it is a matter of judgement, I'd record my dissent on the file, which the system allows. If it is clearly illegal, I would not sign it, and I'd raise it through proper channels while keeping the relationship professional.

Separately, I'd suggest a clearer procedure so that the same issue doesn't come up again."

Likely follow-ups

- Your senior writes an adverse remark in your APAR afterwards. What do you do?
- What is the difference between an illegal and an unwise decision?
- Would you leak the file to the media?

Avoid: Either blind obedience or immediate resignation.

Q22. How would you handle a protest against a development project in your district?

What the board is testing: *Empathy, dialogue and respect for law.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, I'd treat the protest as information, not just a law-and-order problem. People usually protest because they feel unheard or fear losing land, livelihood or water.

I'd meet the protesters' representatives quickly, share the project's facts openly, and check whether consultation, compensation and resettlement were done properly. If they weren't, I'd fix them before pushing ahead.

I'd make sure the protest stays peaceful and that essential services aren't blocked, but I'd avoid force unless there is violence. Where the concerns are valid, I'd take them to the government with recommendations, including design changes."

Likely follow-ups

- What if the protest is politically motivated?
- What does the 2013 land acquisition law require?
- The project has a deadline from the Centre. What then?

Avoid: Treating protesters as obstacles, or promising things you cannot deliver.

Q23. Would you prefer a home-state posting or a conflict-prone border district?

What the board is testing: *Honesty, willingness to serve, and maturity about where you can add value.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, I'd go wherever I'm posted, and I mean that. If I'm asked for my preference, I'd say a difficult district is where a young officer learns the most, and where the state needs committed people.

My home state has its advantages, such as language and local knowledge, but it also has risks of local pressures. A border district would teach me security, coordination with the forces and how to build trust with communities who often feel far from the state.

So I'd welcome either, and I'd prepare for the border district by learning the local language and history first."

Likely follow-ups

- What problems do border districts face?
- How would you build trust with a community that distrusts the state?
- What if your family objects?

Avoid: Sounding reluctant about difficult postings, or claiming you'd prefer hardship just to impress.

SECTION E

Philosophical Questions

Q24. What is the difference between leadership and management?

What the board is testing: *Conceptual clarity and real-life illustration.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, Warren Bennis put it well: managers do things right; leaders do the right thing. Management keeps a system running efficiently. Leadership decides where it should go and why people should follow.

A district needs both. Running a vaccination drive on schedule is management. Persuading a hesitant village to take the vaccine, by sitting with its elders and listening to their fears, is leadership.

In my site work, I learned that people follow you when they see you share the hard parts, not just give instructions."

Likely follow-ups

- Can leadership be taught?
- Give an example of a leader you admire in administration.
- When should a leader not be democratic?

Avoid: A textbook definition with no example.

Q25. Is honesty enough for a civil servant?

What the board is testing: *Depth of ethical understanding.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"No, Sir. Honesty is necessary but not sufficient.

An honest officer who is indifferent, slow, or lacking in competence can still fail the people. A civil servant also needs empathy, courage to take decisions, competence in the work and fairness. The Nolan principles add objectivity, accountability, openness and leadership to integrity.

I'd say honesty is the foundation, but the building is the outcomes you deliver for the citizen at your door."

Likely follow-ups

- What is more dangerous, a corrupt efficient officer or an honest inefficient one?
- What is intellectual honesty?
- How would you develop empathy in your team?

Avoid: Giving a yes-or-no answer without explaining what else is needed.

Q26. Should a civil servant prize intelligence or wisdom?

What the board is testing: *Reflection and value-based thinking.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Wisdom, Sir, though it needs intelligence to work with.

Intelligence helps you analyse a problem quickly and find options. Wisdom helps you choose the right option, at the right time, with the right tone, and to know what you don't know.

In a crisis, a clever plan announced harshly can fail, while a simple plan explained with empathy can work. I'd like to be intelligent enough to see the options and wise enough to listen before deciding."

Likely follow-ups

- Can wisdom be learnt?
- Give an example of a wise decision by an administrator.
- Is experience the same as wisdom?

Avoid: Over-intellectualising. Keep it human and concrete.

Q27. What will India look like in 2047, and what is your role in it?

What the board is testing: *Vision, realism and personal commitment.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, I hope it will be a developed country in the fullest sense: not only high income, but healthy, skilled, safe for women, environmentally secure, and fair to its poorest citizens. The Viksit Bharat goal captures much of that.

Getting there depends less on announcements and more on how well the basic systems work,

schools, primary health, courts, local bodies, in thousands of blocks.

In 2047 I'd be completing about 20 years of service. My role would be to make sure the districts I worked in have measurably better outcomes than when I arrived, and to leave behind systems, not just projects."

Likely follow-ups

- What is the biggest obstacle to that vision?
- Which sector needs the most reform?
- How will you measure your own contribution?

Avoid: Slogans with no grounding, or an overly personal ambition.

SECTION F

Public Administration Optional

Q28. Is bureaucracy a hindrance to development?

What the board is testing: *Balanced use of theory and experience.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Not inherently, Sir. Bureaucracy is the machinery of development; the question is how it is designed and led. **Position.**

Rules, records and hierarchy give continuity and protect citizens from arbitrary power. India's elections, vaccination drives and DBT systems are all delivered by bureaucracy. **Reason.**

But excessive procedure, risk-aversion and a culture of "file over outcome" do slow development, which is what Riggs described as formalism and what NPM tried to fix. **Other side.**

I'd keep accountability while simplifying processes, delegating decisions downward and judging my team by outcomes, not just by files cleared. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- Which reform has made bureaucracy more responsive?
- What is red-tapism, and how would you reduce it?
- Should civil servants be hired on contract?

Avoid: Either bureaucracy-bashing or defensiveness.

Q29. How do you define good governance?

What the board is testing: *Conceptual clarity linked to citizens' experience.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"Sir, the UNDP lists features such as participation, rule of law, transparency, responsiveness, equity, effectiveness and accountability. In simpler terms, I'd define it from the citizen's side: does a person get what they are entitled to, on time, without having to know someone or pay someone?

Measurable signs would be service-delivery timelines met, grievances resolved, and fair outcomes for the poorest. India's Good Governance Index tries to measure some of this at the state level.

In a district, I'd judge good governance by whether the most vulnerable person can walk into my office and be heard."

Likely follow-ups

- What did the 2nd ARC say about citizen-centric administration?
- How would you measure governance in your district?
- Is e-governance the same as good governance?

Avoid: A long list of principles with no illustration.

Q30. Would you favour lateral entry or permanent civil servants?

What the board is testing: *Balance, awareness of recent events and institutional understanding.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"I'd favour a permanent civil service with limited, transparent lateral entry where specialist skills are needed. **Position.**

Domains like technology, finance and infrastructure benefit from people with deep sectoral experience, and several countries combine career and lateral routes. **Reason.**

Concerns are real: transparency in selection, the question of reservation, accountability for short-term appointees, and morale in the regular services. In 2024, an advertisement for lateral recruitment was withdrawn after such concerns were raised. **Other side.**

I'd suggest lateral entry through UPSC or a similar independent body, clear rules on reservation, defined tenures and performance review, and at the same time deeper domain training for career officers, which is what Mission Karmayogi aims for. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- What did the 2nd ARC recommend on lateral entry?
- Would lateral entrants weaken neutrality?
- How do other countries manage it?

Avoid: Taking an extreme position, or ignoring the reservation debate.

Q31. Does RTI help or hamper administration?

What the board is testing: *Commitment to transparency, with practical awareness.*

Model answer (spoken, about 45–60 seconds)

"On balance it helps, Sir. **Position.**

The RTI Act, 2005 made citizens partners in accountability. It has exposed irregularities in schemes and pushed departments to keep better records. Section 4 on proactive disclosure was meant to make many applications unnecessary. **Reason.**

Officers do complain of frivolous or repetitive applications, and pendency in information commissions is high, which weakens the law. **Other side.**

My answer as an officer would be strong proactive disclosure, so that most information is already online, and a well-trained PIO system in my office. Concerns about the 2019 amendments on the tenure of commissioners are also worth discussing openly. **Officer's lens.**"

Likely follow-ups

- Who selects Information Commissioners?
- Should file notings be disclosed?
- How would you reduce RTI pendency in your district?

Avoid: Treating RTI as a burden, or ignoring its practical problems.

A final note

The best answer in the room will always be the one that sounds like you. Use these answers to learn the shape; then fill it with your own life, your own district and your own convictions.

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PART VI

State Profiles

Home-state one-pagers

Every board asks about the home state, and the questions are rarely trivia. They test whether you have looked closely at the place that made you: its history, its people, its economy and its problems. Each profile fits on one page so that you can revise it the night before.

Use the profile as a starting point, not an end. Add your own district on the template in Chapter 17 of the main book, check the latest figures, and practise the five likely questions aloud in the four-beat rhythm.

Data notes: population, sex ratio and literacy are from Census 2011, the latest census available. Per capita income figures are from MoSPI or the RBI Handbook of Statistics on Indian States for the year shown; where a newer figure is published, use it. Recent developments are as of October 2026.

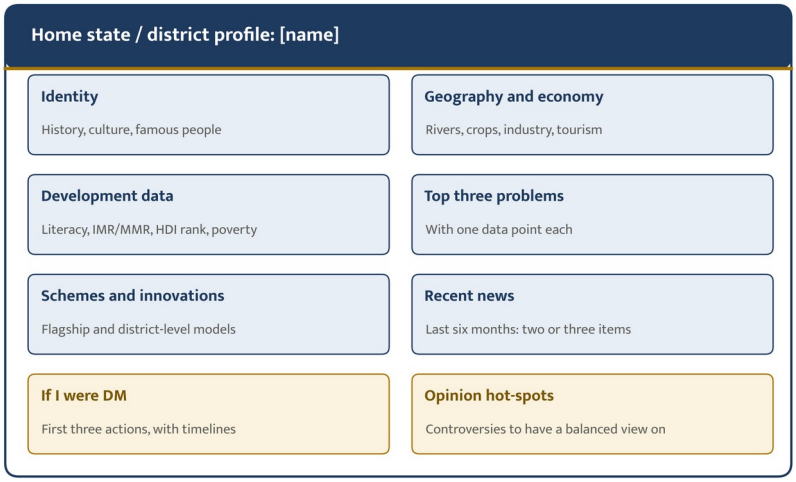


Figure 19. Add your own district on this template (Chapter 17 of the main book)

Uttar Pradesh

India's most populous state: Gangetic heartland, Ayodhya, Kashi and Kumbh, and fast-growing expressways

Capital	Lucknow	**Formed**	24 Jan 1950 (renamed from United Provinces); Uttarakhand carved out 2000
Area	2,40,928 sq km (4th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	19.98 crore (1st)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	912 / 67.7%	**Districts**	75 (18 divisions)
Official / main languages	Hindi; Urdu (second official); Awadhi, Bhojpuri, Braj, Bundeli	**Per capita NSDP**	₹93,422 (2023-24)

History

Ancient Kosala, Kashi and Panchala flourished here; the Buddha gave his first sermon at Sarnath and attained Mahaparinirvana at Kushinagar. Kannauj was Harsha's capital; Agra and Fatehpur Sikri anchored Mughal rule, and Lucknow rose under the Nawabs of Awadh. The 1857 Revolt began at Meerut and spread to Kanpur, Lucknow and Jhansi. Chauri Chaura (1922) halted Non-Cooperation. United Provinces became Uttar Pradesh in 1950.

Society and Culture

Hindi and Urdu dominate, alongside Awadhi, Bhojpuri, Braj and Bundeli. Bhakti saints Kabir, Tulsidas and Surdas shaped its culture; the Aligarh Movement of Sir Syed promoted modern Muslim education. Kathak, Banaras gharana music, chikankari, Banarasi silk and Bhadohi carpets are signature arts. Kumbh, Braj Holi, Dev Deepawali and Ayodhya Deepotsav draw millions. Awadhi cuisine and Ganga-Jamuni tehzeeb reflect a composite heritage.

Economy

GSDP is about ₹30 lakh crore (2024-25), with services 47%, agriculture 27% and manufacturing 26% (PRS). Real growth was estimated at 9% in 2024-25. UP is India's largest producer of sugarcane, milk and potato and grows about a fifth of national foodgrains. Strength: huge market, expressway network and ODOP-led MSME base. Weakness: per capita income remains roughly half the national average, with sharp regional disparities.

Human Geography

Three regions: Bhabar-Terai in the north, the fertile Ganga-Yamuna plain, and the Bundelkhand-Vindhyan plateau in the south. Density is 829 per sq km (2011); only 22% is urban. Large out-migration flows to Delhi, Mumbai and Punjab. Eastern districts face Ghaghra-Rapti floods, Bundelkhand faces drought; heatwaves and lightning are recurrent. Resources include fertile alluvium, groundwater and Sonbhadra's coal-power belt.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Maha Kumbh 2025 at Prayagraj reported about 66 crore visitors. The 594-km Ganga Expressway (Meerut-Prayagraj, 12 districts) opened in April 2026. Noida International Airport, Jewar, began commercial flights on 15 June 2026. The state also tabled its first Economic Survey in February 2026.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why did the 1857 Revolt find such strong support in Awadh?
2. Can expressways alone reduce the gap between western UP and Purvanchal or Bundelkhand?
3. As DM, how would you manage crowd safety at a mega religious gathering like Kumbh?
4. How can ODOP help UP's artisans compete in global markets?
5. Should Uttar Pradesh be divided into smaller states for better governance? Give your view.

Bihar

Ancient Magadha's land of Nalanda and Bodh Gaya, Chhath, Mithila art and makhana

Capital	Patna	**Formed**	22 Mar 1912 (separated from Bengal); Odisha 1936, Jharkhand 2000 carved out
Area	94,163 sq km (12th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	10.41 crore (3rd)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	918 / 61.8%	**Districts**	38
Official / main languages	Hindi; Urdu (second official); Maithili, Bhojpuri, Magahi, Angika	**Per capita NSDP**	₹60,180 (2023-24)

History

Magadha, with capitals at Rajgriha and Pataliputra, nurtured the Mauryan and Gupta empires; Vaishali was an early republic. The Buddha attained enlightenment at Bodh Gaya and Mahavira was born near Vaishali. Nalanda and Vikramshila were renowned universities. Sher Shah Suri rose from Sasaram. Gandhi's Champaran Satyagraha (1917) began here, and the JP Movement (1974) shook national politics. Bihar became a province in 1912.

Society and Culture

Hindi and Urdu are official; Maithili (Eighth Schedule), Bhojpuri, Magahi and Angika are widely spoken. Chhath Puja is the defining festival; the Sonepur cattle fair is historic. Madhubani painting, Manjusha art, Sikki grass craft and Bhagalpuri silk are notable. Litti-chokha, sattu and makhana mark the cuisine. Bhikhari Thakur's folk theatre, social justice movements, total prohibition (2016) and Jeevika women's SHGs shape social life.

Economy

Services contribute 58.6%, industry 21.5% and agriculture 19.9% of GSDP (2023-24). Real growth was 8.6% in 2024-25, above the national rate. Bihar produces about 90% of India's makhana and leads in litchi; maize, rice and fisheries are rising. Strength: consistently high growth and expanding roads. Weakness: India's lowest per capita income, a thin industrial base and a low credit-deposit ratio (56.3%).

Human Geography

The Ganga divides flood-prone North Bihar, fed by the Kosi, Gandak and Bagmati from Nepal, from drier South Bihar bordering the Chotanagpur plateau. Density is 1,106 per sq km, India's highest (2011), while only 11% is urban. Seasonal out-migration of labour is large. Floods, drought, lightning, heatwaves and high seismic risk recur. Fertile alluvium and groundwater are key resources; most minerals went to Jharkhand.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

The November 2025 Assembly election, held after a Special Intensive Revision of rolls, recorded 66.91% turnout, the highest since 1951, with women at 71.6%. In September 2025 the National Makhana Board and Purnea Airport were launched, with foundation stones laid for the Kosi-Mechi river link and the Pirpainti thermal power project.

Likely Interview Questions

1. What made Nalanda a global centre of learning, and why did it decline?
2. Why has Bihar's high GSDP growth not translated into higher per capita income?
3. As DM of a Kosi-belt district, how would you prepare for annual floods?
4. How can makhana and litchi value chains raise farm incomes in Bihar?
5. Has prohibition in Bihar achieved its social objectives? Give a balanced view.

Rajasthan

India's largest state: desert, forts, Rajput heritage, minerals and solar power

Capital	Jaipur	**Formed**	30 Mar 1949 (Rajasthan Day); present form 1 Nov 1956
Area	3,42,239 sq km (1st)	**Population (Census 2011)**	6.85 crore (7th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	928 / 66.1%	**Districts**	41 (since Dec 2024)
Official / main languages	Hindi; Rajasthani dialects (Marwari, Mewari, Dhundhari, Mewati)	**Per capita NSDP**	₹1,85,053 (2024-25)

History

Home to Kalibangan (Harappan) and Bairat (Ashokan edicts), the region later saw Rajput kingdoms such as Mewar, Marwar and Amber resist and ally with Delhi Sultans and Mughals; Chittorgarh and Haldighati (1576) are emblematic. Most princely states accepted British paramountcy in 1818. Praja Mandals drove the freedom struggle. Integration of 19 princely states occurred in seven stages (1948–1956), completed after the States Reorganisation Act, 1956 added Ajmer and Abu.

Society and Culture

Hindi is official, with Rajasthani dialects widely spoken. Communities include Rajputs, Jats, Meenas, Bhils, Gujjars and Marwari traders. Festivals: Teej, Gangaur, Pushkar Fair and Desert Festival. Art forms include Ghoomar and Kalbelia dances, Phad painting, Kathputli, blue pottery and bandhej. Cuisine: dal-baati-churma, ker-sangri, gatte. Bishnoi conservation ethic (Khejarli, 1730) and MKSS's Right to Information campaign are notable social movements.

Economy

Economic Review 2025-26 puts GSDP at ₹18.75 lakh crore, growing 10.24% at current prices; services contribute 47.7% of GSVA, industry 26.5%, agriculture 25.7%. Rajasthan leads in bajra, mustard and guar, and produces lead-zinc, marble, sandstone and crude oil (Barmer). Tourism, cement and textiles matter. Strength: large solar and wind potential with leading installed capacity. Weakness: acute water scarcity, low female labour participation and high public debt.

Human Geography

The Aravallis divide the arid Thar west from the eastern plains and Hadoti plateau. Population concentrates in the east and the Jaipur–Ajmer–Kota belt; the west is sparse. About a quarter of people are urban. Seasonal out-migration to Gujarat and Gulf is common. Hazards include drought, desertification, dust storms, heatwaves and flash floods. Resources: minerals, solar radiation, Indira Gandhi Canal irrigation.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

July 2026: Prime Minister launched projects worth about ₹1.06 lakh crore at Balotra, including the Rajasthan Refinery, a new Jodhpur airport terminal and Jaipur Metro Phase-II. A Rajasthan–Haryana arrangement plans a Yamuna (Hathnikund) pipeline to Shekhawati. Dec 2024: nine new districts created in 2023 were cancelled.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why did Rajasthan's integration take seven stages, and what role did Sardar Patel play?
2. How can the Bishnoi conservation tradition inform modern desert ecology policy?
3. Rajasthan leads in solar capacity; how should land and grid issues be resolved?
4. As DM of Barmer facing drought and water tanker mafia, what would you do?
5. Is creating more small districts good for governance? Give your opinion.

Madhya Pradesh

Heart of India: tigers, forests, tribal culture, soybean and ancient temples

Capital	Bhopal	**Formed**	1 Nov 1956 (reorganised); Chhattisgarh carved out 1 Nov 2000
Area	3,08,252 sq km (2nd)	**Population (Census 2011)**	7.27 crore (5th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	931 / 69.3%	**Districts**	55 (since 2023)
Official / main languages	Hindi; Bundeli, Malwi, Nimadi, Bagheli, Gondi, Bhili	**Per capita NSDP**	₹1,52,615 (2024-25)

History

Bhimbetka rock shelters show prehistoric life; Sanchi stupa marks Mauryan Buddhism and Ujjain (Avanti) was a Mahajanapada capital. Paramaras, Chandelas (Khajuraho) and Gonds ruled; Malwa Sultanate built Mandu. Marathas—Holkars, Scindias—dominated before British control. Tantia Tope and Rani Avantibai fought in 1857. The state was formed in 1956 by merging Madhya Bharat, Vindhya Pradesh, Bhopal and Mahakoshal; Chhattisgarh separated in 2000.

Society and Culture

Hindi dominates alongside Bundeli, Malwi and tribal languages. MP has India's largest Scheduled Tribe population, including Bhils, Gonds and Baigas. Festivals: Bhagoria, Simhastha Kumbh at Ujjain, Khajuraho Dance Festival. Art forms: Gond and Bhil painting, Pithora, Chanderi and Maheshwari weaving, Tansen-linked Gwalior music tradition. Cuisine: poha-jalebi, dal-bafla, bhutte ka kees. Bhopal gas tragedy (1984) activism and Narmada Bachao Andolan shaped public discourse.

Economy

Economic Survey 2025-26 estimates GSDP at about ₹16.69 lakh crore, growing 11.14% nominal and 8.04% real; primary sector 43.1%, secondary 19.8%, tertiary 37.1%. MP leads in soybean and pulses and is a major wheat producer; Panna diamonds, Malanjkhand copper and Balaghat manganese are notable. Strength: high agricultural growth and irrigation expansion. Weakness: thin industrial base, low per capita income and malnutrition in tribal districts.

Human Geography

Physiographic units include the Malwa plateau, Vindhya and Satpura ranges, Bundelkhand, Baghelkhand and Narmada–Tapti rift valleys. It has India's largest forest cover. Population concentrates in Malwa and river plains; tribal belts are sparse. Urbanisation is about 28%. Bundelkhand sees distress migration. Hazards: drought, floods, heatwaves, Narmada valley seismicity. Resources: coal (Singrauli), forests, hydropower.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Feb 2026: Budget 2026-27 of ₹4.38 lakh crore earmarked ₹13,851 crore for Simhastha 2028 at Ujjain. The state declared 2026 'Krishak Kalyan Varsh' (Farmers' Welfare Year) and aims to expand irrigation. Dec 2025: the state was declared Naxal-free after the last cadres surrendered in Balaghat.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why is Sanchi important for understanding Ashoka's dhamma and Buddhist art?
2. MP has India's largest tribal population; how should PESA be implemented better?
3. How can Madhya Pradesh move beyond agriculture towards manufacturing and services?
4. As DM of Ujjain during Simhastha, how would you manage crowd safety?
5. Should cheetah reintroduction continue despite deaths? Give a balanced opinion.

Maharashtra

India's largest state economy, home to Mumbai, the financial and film capital

Capital	Mumbai (winter capital: Nagpur)	**Formed**	1 May 1960 (bifurcation of Bombay State)
Area	3,07,713 sq km (3rd)	**Population (Census 2011)**	11.24 crore (2nd)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	929 / 82.3%	**Districts**	36
Official / main languages	Marathi	**Per capita NSDP**	₹3,09,340 (2024-25)

History

Ruled by Satavahanas, Vakatakas, Chalukyas, Rashtrakutas and Yadavas, the region later saw the Bahmani and Deccan sultanates. Shivaji founded the Maratha Swarajya, crowned in 1674; the Peshwas extended Maratha power across India until British victory in 1818. Bombay grew as a colonial port and hub of the national movement, hosting the first INC session (1885) and the Quit India call (1942). The Samyukta Maharashtra movement produced the state on 1 May 1960.

Society and Culture

Marathi dominates, alongside Konkani, Hindi, Urdu and tribal languages such as Gondi and Warli. Major festivals include Ganeshotsav, popularised publicly by Tilak, Gudi Padwa and the Pandharpur Wari. Lavani, Tamasha, Warli painting and Paithani weaving are signature arts. Cuisine ranges from vada pav and misal to Malvani seafood. Reformers Jyotirao and Savitribai Phule, Shahu Maharaj and B.R. Ambedkar shaped anti-caste and women's education movements.

Economy

Largest state GSDP, about ₹46.2 lakh crore (2024-25), with estimated real growth of 7.3%. Services contribute 63%, industry 24% and agriculture 13%. Key sectors: banking and finance, IT, automobiles (Pune, Chakan), pharmaceuticals, petrochemicals and film. Crops include sugarcane, cotton, soybean, onion and grapes. Strength: deep capital markets and a leading investment destination. Weakness: sharp regional disparity, with rain-fed Marathwada and Vidarbha facing agrarian distress.

Human Geography

Regions: the narrow Konkan coast, the Sahyadri (Western Ghats) and the Deccan basalt plateau covering Desh, Marathwada and Vidarbha. About 45% of people were urban (2011), concentrated in the Mumbai–Pune–Nashik belt, a magnet for interstate migrants. Rain-shadow interiors face drought; coasts face cyclones and Mumbai urban floods. The Koyna area is seismically active. Resources: coal and manganese in Vidarbha, bauxite in Konkan.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Navi Mumbai International Airport began commercial flights on 25 December 2025. Extreme rains in September 2025 damaged crops on over 68 lakh hectares across 29 districts, prompting a ₹31,628 crore relief package for farmers. Work continues on the Vadhavan deep-draft port in Palghar.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why did the Samyukta Maharashtra movement succeed, and what was Bombay's role in it?
2. How are the ideas of Phule and Ambedkar relevant to Maharashtra's social policy today?
3. Why does Maharashtra's high GSDP coexist with farm distress in Marathwada and Vidarbha?
4. As Collector of a flood-hit Marathwada district, what would be your first 72-hour priorities?
5. Should Mumbai have a directly elected mayor with stronger metropolitan powers? Why?

Delhi (National Capital Territory)

India's national capital, blending Sultanate and Mughal heritage with a vast services economy

Capital	New Delhi	**Formed**	NCT since 1992 (69th Amendment)
Area	1,483 sq km	**Population (Census 2011)**	1.68 crore (19th among states and UTs)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	868 / 86.2%	**Districts**	13 (since Dec 2025)
Official / main languages	Hindi; Punjabi and Urdu (second official)	**Per capita NSDP**	₹4,59,408 (2023-24)

History

Linked in tradition to Indraprastha, Delhi became a power centre under the Tomars and Chauhans. The Delhi Sultanate and the Mughals built successive cities, from the Qutb complex to Shahjahanabad and the Red Fort. Delhi was a focal point of the 1857 revolt. The British shifted the capital from Calcutta in 1911 and inaugurated New Delhi in 1931. Partition refugees reshaped the city. The 69th Amendment created the NCT, with an elected Assembly from 1993.

Society and Culture

Hindi is dominant; Punjabi and Urdu are second official languages, and English is widely used. Partition refugees and migrants from across India make Delhi cosmopolitan. Festivals include Diwali, Eid, Gurpurab, Chhath and Phool Walon Ki Sair, a syncretic tradition. Qawwali at Nizamuddin dargah and Kathak endure. Chandni Chowk street food, Mughlai and Punjabi cuisine define its palate. Red Fort, Qutb Minar and Humayun's Tomb are UNESCO World Heritage Sites.

Economy

GSDP is estimated at about ₹13.3 lakh crore (2025-26), with real growth of 8.5%. Services contribute 86%, industry 13% and agriculture 1%. Key sectors: trade, real estate, finance, IT, hospitality, transport and public administration. Per capita income is about ₹5.93 lakh (2025-26), more than double the national level. Strength: a skilled, high-income services base. Weakness: severe winter air pollution and a polluted Yamuna impose heavy health and productivity costs.

Human Geography

Delhi lies on the Indo-Gangetic plain between the Aravalli Ridge and the Yamuna floodplain. With 97.5% of people urban and 11,320 persons per sq km (2011), it is India's most densely populated state/UT. Sustained in-migration has produced unauthorised colonies and JJ clusters. Hazards: high earthquake risk, Yamuna floods, heatwaves, water scarcity and winter smog. Water supply depends heavily on inter-state river sharing.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Delhi's revenue districts were reorganised from 11 to 13 in December 2025. Cloud-seeding trials against air pollution were conducted with IIT Kanpur in October 2025. In March 2026, two new Metro corridors opened, Phase 5-A works began, and GPRA colony redevelopment worth about ₹15,200 crore was launched.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why did the British shift India's capital from Calcutta to Delhi in 1911?
2. How has Partition shaped Delhi's demography, culture and urban form?
3. Should Delhi get full statehood, given its status as the national capital?
4. As DM, how would you manage a severe smog emergency under GRAP Stage IV?
5. Can Delhi's services-led economy sustain growth without solving its pollution problem?

Haryana

Green Revolution granary, automobile and IT hub, wrestlers and Kurukshetra's heritage

Capital	Chandigarh (shared with Punjab)	**Formed**	1 Nov 1966 (Punjab Reorganisation Act)
Area	44,212 sq km (20th among states)	**Population (Census 2011)**	2.54 crore (18th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	879 / 75.6%	**Districts**	23 (Hansi added Dec 2025)
Official / main languages	Hindi; Punjabi (second official); Haryanvi widely spoken	**Per capita NSDP**	₹3,53,182 (2024-25)

History

Rakhigarhi and Banawali are major Harappan sites; Kurukshetra is linked to the Mahabharata. Thanesar was Harshavardhana's early capital. Panipat hosted decisive battles in 1526, 1556 and 1761. Haryana rose in 1857 under leaders like Rao Tula Ram. Sir Chhotu Ram championed peasants' rights. Created from Punjab in 1966 on linguistic lines, Haryana later led the Green Revolution and industrialisation around Delhi.

Society and Culture

Hindi and Haryanvi dominate; Punjabi is second official language. Major communities include Jats, Ahirs, Gujjars, Brahmins, Punjabis and Meos. Festivals: Teej, Baisakhi, Gita Jayanti, Surajkund Crafts Mela. Folk forms: Saang, Ragini, Phag dance. Cuisine: bajra roti, kadhi, lassi, churma. Strong sporting culture yields Olympic wrestlers and boxers. Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (launched Panipat, 2015) addressed skewed child sex ratio.

Economy

PRS estimates 2024-25 shares: services 54%, manufacturing 28%, agriculture 18%; real GSDP growth about 9.5% in 2025-26 and per capita GSDP ₹4.41 lakh. Wheat, paddy, mustard, cotton and dairy dominate farming. Gurugram–Manesar is an automobile and IT/GCC hub; Panipat textiles and Faridabad engineering matter. Strength: high per capita income and NCR connectivity. Weakness: groundwater depletion, youth unemployment, stubble burning and regional disparity.

Human Geography

Regions include the Shivalik hills, Ghaggar–Yamuna alluvial plain, the semi-arid southwest and Aravalli outliers in Mewat. Population concentrates in NCR districts and the GT Road belt; about 35% is urban. Gurugram and Faridabad attract heavy in-migration. Hazards: groundwater decline, floods (Yamuna, Ghaggar), air pollution, heatwaves and seismic zone IV near Delhi. Resources: fertile soils, canals, limited minerals.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Dec 2025: Hansi carved out of Hisar as the 23rd district. Mar 2026: Budget 2026-27 of ₹2.24 lakh crore launched a Haryana AI Mission, a World Bank-supported Clean Air Project and free HPV vaccination for adolescent girls. Haryana agreed to supply Yamuna water to Rajasthan's Shekhawati.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why are Rakhigarhi's findings significant for debates on Harappan ancestry?
2. How should Haryana balance paddy cultivation with its rapidly falling water table?
3. Gurugram's growth is uneven; what urban governance reforms would you propose?
4. As DM of Kaithal, how would you curb stubble burning before winter?
5. Has Haryana's sex ratio improvement come from mindset change or enforcement? Your view.

Uttarakhand

Devbhoomi of the Char Dham, Himalayan glaciers, Ganga's source and Chipko movement

Capital	Dehradun (winter); Bhararisain, Gairsain (summer, since 2020)	**Formed**	9 Nov 2000 (as Uttaranchal; renamed 2007)
Area	53,483 sq km (18th among states)	**Population (Census 2011)**	1.01 crore (19th among states)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	963 / 78.8%	**Districts**	13
Official / main languages	Hindi, Sanskrit (second official); Garhwali, Kumaoni	**Per capita NSDP**	₹2,74,064 (2024-25)

History

Mentioned as Kedarkhand and Manaskhand in the Puranas, the region was ruled by the Katyuris, then the Chand (Kumaon) and Panwar (Garhwal) dynasties. Gorkha rule (1790–1815) ended with the Anglo-Nepal War and British control. The Kuli Begar abolition movement (1921) and Tehri praja mandal agitation marked the freedom era. A prolonged statehood movement, including the 1994 Rampur Tiraha firing, led to separation from Uttar Pradesh in 2000.

Society and Culture

Garhwali, Kumaoni and Jaunsari communities live alongside Tharu, Bhotia, Buksa and Raji tribes. Festivals include Phool Dei, Harela, Uttarayani and the Nanda Devi Raj Jat; Haridwar hosts the Kumbh. Folk forms include Jagar, Chholiya, Pandav Nritya and Aipan art. Cuisine features mandua, jhangora, kafuli and bal mithai. The Chipko movement (1973), led by Gaura Devi and others, inspired forest conservation and women's activism.

Economy

In 2023-24, manufacturing contributed about 47% of GSDP, services 43% and agriculture 10%. Pharma, auto and FMCG units in Haridwar, Pantnagar and Sitarganj, plus hydropower and pilgrimage tourism, drive growth. Per capita GSDP was ₹2,95,751 in 2023-24, above India's average. Strength: tax-incentivised industrial clusters and tourism potential. Weakness: growth concentrated in plains districts, leaving hill economies stagnant and fuelling out-migration.

Human Geography

Regions: Greater Himalaya with glaciers (Gangotri, Pindari), Middle Himalaya, Shivaliks, Doon valleys, Bhabar and Terai. Nearly two-thirds of land is forest. Population concentrates in Dehradun, Haridwar and Udham Singh Nagar; urbanisation about 30%. Hill out-migration has left many 'ghost villages'. Hazards: earthquakes, cloudbursts, landslides, GLOFs and forest fires. Resources: water, hydropower, forests and medicinal herbs.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Uttarakhand became the first state to implement a Uniform Civil Code on 27 January 2025. A flash flood on the Kheer Ganga devastated Dharali, Uttarkashi, on 5 August 2025. The state marked its silver jubilee in November 2025 and is preparing for the 2027 Haridwar Kumbh.

Likely Interview Questions

1. What was the significance of the Chipko movement for India's environmental governance?
2. How can Uttarakhand reduce out-migration from hill districts and revive 'ghost villages'?
3. As DM of Chamoli, how will you manage a cloudburst during the Char Dham Yatra?
4. Is large-scale hydropower in the Himalaya compatible with ecological safety?
5. What is your opinion on Uttarakhand's Uniform Civil Code as a model for other states?

Jharkhand

Land of forests: Chotanagpur's mineral wealth, tribal heritage and Birsa Munda's legacy

Capital	Ranchi	**Formed**	15 Nov 2000 (Bihar Reorganisation Act, 2000)
Area	79,716 sq km (15th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	3.30 crore (14th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	948 / 66.4%	**Districts**	24
Official / main languages	Hindi; second official incl. Urdu, Santali, Mundari, Ho, Kurukh, Bengali	**Per capita NSDP**	₹1,05,274 (2023-24)

History

The Chotanagpur and Santhal Pargana tribes resisted colonial land and revenue systems through the Kol Rebellion (1831-32), the Santhal Hul of Sidhu-Kanhu (1855) and Birsa Munda's Ulgulan (1899-1900), which led to the Chotanagpur Tenancy Act, 1908. Tana Bhagats joined the national movement. Jaipal Singh Munda's Jharkhand Party and later the JMM led the statehood struggle, achieved on 15 November 2000, Birsa Munda's birth anniversary.

Society and Culture

Scheduled Tribes form 26.2% of the population; major groups include Santhal, Oraon, Munda and Ho. Santali (Ol Chiki script), Mundari, Ho, Kurukh, Khortha and Nagpuri are spoken. Sarhul, Karma and Sohrai mark the agrarian calendar. Sohrai-Khovar wall painting and Seraikela Chhau dance are signature arts; dhuska and handia are traditional food and drink. Gram Sabha assertion and land-rights movements remain socially significant.

Economy

Industry and mining weigh heavily; services are now the largest sector and agriculture about 12% of GSVA (2025-26). Real growth was 7.02% in 2024-25, above the national average. Jharkhand leads in coal reserves and mines iron ore, copper, mica and uranium; Jamshedpur and Bokaro anchor steel. Strength: mineral-industrial base. Weakness: about 28.8% multidimensional poverty (2019-21) and rainfed, mono-crop farming.

Human Geography

The Chotanagpur plateau dominates, with the Ranchi and Hazaribagh plateaus, Rajmahal hills and the Damodar, Subarnarekha and Koel basins. Forests cover nearly 30% of the area. About 24% is urban (2011), concentrated in Ranchi, Dhanbad, Jamshedpur and Bokaro. Mining-related displacement and seasonal migration are major issues. Hazards include drought, lightning, elephant conflict and Jharia coal-field fires and subsidence.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Jharkhand celebrated 25 years of statehood on 15 November 2025, coinciding with Birsa Munda's 150th birth anniversary. It notified PESA Rules on 2 January 2026, empowering Gram Sabhas in Scheduled Areas over forest produce, minor minerals and land. Its Economic Survey 2025-26 reported per capita income crossing ₹1 lakh in 2024-25.

Likely Interview Questions

1. What were the causes and outcomes of Birsa Munda's Ulgulan?
2. Why does mineral-rich Jharkhand still have high poverty? Is it a resource curse?
3. As DM, how would you rehabilitate families displaced by a new coal mine?
4. How can the new PESA Rules strengthen tribal self-governance in practice?
5. Has the creation of Jharkhand fulfilled the aspirations of its tribal people? Your view.

Odisha

Land of Jagannath and Konark, mineral-rich and a model in cyclone preparedness

Capital	Bhubaneswar	**Formed**	1 Apr 1936 (separate province; Utkal Divas)
Area	1,55,707 sq km (8th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	4.20 crore (11th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	979 / 72.87%	**Districts**	30 (since 1993)
Official / main languages	Odia; Santali and other tribal languages	**Per capita NSDP**	₹1,82,548 (2024-25)

History

Ancient Kalinga, whose war (c. 261 BCE) turned Ashoka towards dhamma; Kharavela's Hathigumpha inscription records Jain-era glory. The Eastern Gangas built the Puri and Konark temples. The Paika Rebellion (1817) challenged British rule. The Odia language movement led by Madhusudan Das produced a separate province on 1 April 1936, the first on linguistic lines. Princely states merged in 1948-49, and Orissa was renamed Odisha in 2011.

Society and Culture

Odia is the official language; Scheduled Tribes form about 22.8% of the population (2011), with 62 tribes including the Santal and Kondh and 13 PVTGs. Rath Yatra at Puri, Raja Parba and Durga Puja are key festivals. Odissi and Gotipua dance, Pattachitra, Cuttack silver filigree and Sambalpuri ikat are renowned. Dalma, pakhala and chhena poda define the cuisine. Utkalmani Gopabandhu Das led social and educational reform.

Economy

Industry contributes about 41%, services 39% and agriculture and allied about 20% of GSVA (2025-26). Rich in iron ore, bauxite, chromite and coal, it hosts steel, aluminium and power plants, while Paradip is a leading cargo port. Real GSDP growth is projected at 7.9% (2025-26); per capita NSDP is ₹1,82,548 (2024-25). Strength: low debt, about 13.6% of GSDP. Weakness: tribal poverty and distress migration.

Human Geography

Four regions: the northern plateau, the Eastern Ghats hills, the central tableland and the coastal plains with the Mahanadi delta and Chilika lagoon. Population is dense on the coast and sparse in tribal highlands; only 16.7% was urban in 2011. Seasonal labour migrates from Bolangir, Nuapada and Kalahandi. Hazards include cyclones, floods, drought, heatwaves and lightning. Resources: iron ore, bauxite, chromite, coal, forests and fisheries.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

The Union Cabinet approved two semiconductor units at Bhubaneswar (August 2025), including SiCSem's silicon carbide fab. The Economic Survey 2025-26 placed GSDP near ₹9.9 lakh crore. The fifth Subhadra scheme instalment reached about 1.03 crore women (August 2026).

Likely Interview Questions

1. How did the Kalinga War change Ashoka's approach to governance?
2. What makes Jagannath culture and the Puri Rath Yatra unique?
3. Mineral-rich Odisha has low per capita income. How can this paradox be addressed?
4. As Collector of a coastal district, how would you ensure zero casualties in a cyclone?
5. Should mining royalties be shared directly with affected tribal communities? Give your opinion.

West Bengal

Land of the Bengal Renaissance, Durga Puja, Sundarbans and Darjeeling tea

Capital	Kolkata	**Formed**	15 Aug 1947 (Partition of Bengal); state from 26 Jan 1950
Area	88,752 sq km (13th among states)	**Population (Census 2011)**	9.13 crore (4th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	950 / 76.3%	**Districts**	23 (5 more proposed in 2026-27 Budget)
Official / main languages	Bengali, English; Nepali, Hindi, Urdu, Santali and others regionally	**Per capita NSDP**	₹1,63,467 (2024-25)

History

Seat of the Pala and Sena dynasties and later the Bengal Sultanate and Nawabs. Plassey (1757) and Buxar (1764) opened British rule; Calcutta was India's capital until 1911. The Bengal Renaissance, the 1905 Partition and Swadeshi movement, and revolutionaries like Subhas Chandra Bose shaped nationalism. The 1947 Partition created West Bengal amid a refugee influx; later came land reforms (Operation Barga) and the Naxalbari uprising.

Society and Culture

Bengali dominates, with Nepali, Santali, Hindi and Urdu speakers; communities include Rajbanshis, Santals, Gorkhas and Matuas. Durga Puja is UNESCO-listed intangible heritage; Poila Baisakh, Kali Puja and Poush Mela are celebrated. Baul music, Rabindra Sangeet, Chhau, Kantha, terracotta temples and Kalighat painting thrive. Cuisine features fish, rice and sweets like rosogolla. Reformers include Ram Mohan Roy, Vidyasagar, Vivekananda and Tagore.

Economy

Services contribute about 55% of GSVA, industry 24% and agriculture 21% (2021-22). The state leads in rice, jute, fish and Darjeeling tea; MSMEs, leather, engineering and Kolkata-Haldia ports anchor industry. Real GSDP growth is estimated at 7.6% (2025-26). Strength: large MSME base and fertile delta. Weakness: per capita income about 20% below national level and high debt (38.4% of GSDP, 2022-23).

Human Geography

Regions: Darjeeling Himalaya, Terai-Dooars, northern plains, western Chhotanagpur plateau fringe, Ganga delta and the Sundarbans coast. Density is among India's highest (1,028 per sq km). Urbanisation is about 32%, centred on Kolkata. Labour out-migration and cross-border inflows matter. Hazards: cyclones, floods, river-bank erosion and hill landslides. Resources: Raniganj coal, fertile alluvium, fisheries and forests.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

April 2026 Assembly polls recorded a record turnout of about 92%; results on 4 May brought a change of government. The 2026-27 Budget replaced Lakshmir Bhandar with the Annapurna Bhandar cash transfer for women and proposed five new districts. Ghatal Master Plan flood works are under way.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why did the Bengal Renaissance begin in Calcutta rather than elsewhere in India?
2. Why has West Bengal's share in India's industrial output declined since independence?
3. As DM of South 24 Parganas, how will you prepare for a severe cyclone?
4. How can the state balance tea-garden workers' welfare with plantation viability?
5. Should cash-transfer schemes for women replace investment in jobs? Give your view.

Tamil Nadu

Dravidian heartland of temples, classical Tamil culture and a leading manufacturing hub

Capital	Chennai	**Formed**	1 Nov 1956 (as Madras State); renamed 1969
Area	1,30,060 sq km (10th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	7.21 crore (6th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	996 / 80.1%	**Districts**	38 (since 2020)
Official / main languages	Tamil; English	**Per capita NSDP**	₹3,58,027 (2024-25)

History

Home to the Sangam age and the Chera, Chola and Pandya kingdoms; the Cholas built a maritime empire reaching Southeast Asia. Pallavas, Vijayanagara and the Nayaks followed. Fort St George (1639) made Madras a British base. The Justice Party and Periyar's Self-Respect Movement shaped Dravidian politics. Madras State was reorganised in 1956 and renamed Tamil Nadu in 1969, after the anti-Hindi agitations.

Society and Culture

Tamil, declared a classical language in 2004, has a literary tradition from Sangam poetry to the Thirukkural. Bharatanatyam, Carnatic music, Chola bronzes and Tanjore painting flourish. Pongal, Deepavali and Karthigai Deepam are major festivals; jallikattu remains contested. Cuisine ranges from idli and dosa to Chettinad dishes. Periyar's anti-caste rationalism, 69% reservation and the noon-meal scheme define its social-justice legacy.

Economy

Services contribute about 54% of GSVA, industry 33% and agriculture only 6.6% (2024-25). Real GSDP grew 11.19% in 2024-25, the highest among major states (MoSPI). Automobiles around Chennai, electronics, textiles (Tiruppur), leather and IT anchor growth. Strength: diversified, MSME-rich manufacturing spread across many clusters. Weakness: low employment of young women, rising committed spending on salaries and pensions, and water stress in agriculture.

Human Geography

Eastern Coastal Plains, the Kaveri delta, the Western Ghats and Nilgiris in the west, and dry interior plateaus. About 48% urban (2011), among the most urbanised large states, with population spread across many towns. Hazards: cyclones, northeast-monsoon floods in Chennai, droughts. Attracts migrant workers from northern states. Resources: wind energy, lignite (Neyveli), granite and coastal fisheries.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

The April 2026 Assembly election produced a hung house; C. Joseph Vijay (TVK) became Chief Minister on 10 May 2026. The Supreme Court ordered a CBI probe into the September 2025 Karur rally stampede that killed 41. Power transmission and distribution upgrades were announced in August 2026.

Likely Interview Questions

1. How did the Self-Respect Movement shape Tamil Nadu's social and political life?
2. Why has Tamil Nadu become a leading manufacturing state, and what risks does it face?
3. As Collector, how would you ensure crowd safety at a large political rally after Karur?
4. Should jallikattu continue as a cultural right despite animal welfare concerns? Give your view.
5. Is Tamil Nadu's two-language policy an asset or a barrier for its youth?

Kerala (Keralam)

God's Own Country: high human development, Gulf remittances, spices and backwaters

Capital	Thiruvananthapuram	**Formed**	1 Nov 1956 (reorganised); renamed Keralam 2026
Area	38,852 sq km (21st)	**Population (Census 2011)**	3.34 crore (13th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	1,084 / 94.0%	**Districts**	14
Official / main languages	Malayalam; English	**Per capita NSDP**	₹2,79,751 (2023-24)

History

Ancient trade with Romans, Arabs and Chinese through Muziris made Kerala the spice coast. The Cheras, and later the Zamorins of Calicut, Travancore and Cochin, ruled. Vasco da Gama landed in 1498, followed by Portuguese, Dutch and British powers. Travancore pioneered mass education. Kerala was formed on 1 November 1956 by merging Travancore-Cochin with Malabar; in 1957 it elected India's first Communist state government.

Society and Culture

Malayalam is the main language; Hindus, Muslims and Christians form a plural society. Onam, Vishu, Eid and Christmas are widely celebrated. Kathakali, Mohiniyattam, Theyyam, Koodiyattam and Kalaripayattu are distinctive. Cuisine features rice, coconut, seafood and the sadya feast. Sree Narayana Guru, Ayyankali, Chattampi Swamikal and the Vaikom Satyagraha (1924-25) drove reform, followed by near-universal literacy and the 1996 People's Plan decentralisation.

Economy

Services form about 63% of GSVA, industry 28% and the primary sector 8% (2024-25). Real GSDP grew 6.19% in 2024-25. Key sectors: tourism, Gulf remittances, IT, spices, rubber, coconut, cashew and fisheries. Strength: excellent human development and health outcomes. Weakness: high educated unemployment, a thin manufacturing base and a widening fiscal deficit (3.86% of GSDP in 2024-25).

Human Geography

Three parallel belts: Western Ghats highlands, midland hills, and coastal lowlands with backwaters and 44 rivers. Densely populated (860 per sq km, 2011), with a rural-urban continuum; 47.7% urban. Heavy emigration to the Gulf and inflow of migrant workers. Hazards: landslides (Wayanad 2024), floods (2018), coastal erosion. Resources: mineral sands, forests and plantation crops.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Kerala declared itself free of extreme poverty in November 2025. After the 2026 Assembly elections, V.D. Satheesan was sworn in as Chief Minister in May 2026. Parliament renamed the state Keralam, effective 25 August 2026. Vizhinjam port began full export-import operations in August 2026.

Likely Interview Questions

1. How did the Vaikom Satyagraha and Sree Narayana Guru transform Kerala society?
2. Kerala has high literacy but high educated unemployment. Why, and what is the remedy?
3. As Collector of a landslide-prone district like Wayanad, what preparedness steps would you take?
4. Is Kerala's remittance-dependent economy sustainable? Give your view.
5. What does Vizhinjam port mean for India's transshipment ambitions?

Karnataka

India's tech capital state: IT, Vijayanagara heritage, coffee, silk and Kannada culture

Capital	Bengaluru	**Formed**	1 Nov 1956 (as Mysore State); renamed 1973
Area	1,91,791 sq km (6th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	6.11 crore (8th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	973 / 75.4%	**Districts**	31 (since 2021)
Official / main languages	Kannada	**Per capita NSDP**	₹3,80,906 (2024-25)

History

Kadambas, Gangas, Chalukyas, Rashtrakutas and Hoysalas ruled here, leaving temples at Badami, Pattadakal and Belur-Halebidu. The Vijayanagara empire, with its capital at Hampi, dominated the 14th-16th centuries. Hyder Ali and Tipu Sultan resisted the British; the Wodeyars then ruled Mysore as a princely state. The Karnataka unification movement produced a linguistic Mysore State in 1956, renamed Karnataka in 1973.

Society and Culture

Kannada has a classical literature and eight Jnanpith awardees. Lingayats, Vokkaligas, Dalits, OBCs, Muslims and Christians form a diverse society. Mysuru Dasara, Ugadi and Bengaluru Karaga are major festivals; Yakshagana, Hindustani and Carnatic music thrive. Cuisine includes bisi bele bath, ragi mudde and Mysore pak. Basavanna's 12th-century Vachana movement challenged caste; Mysore's 1918 Miller Committee pioneered backward-class reservation.

Economy

Services contribute about 66% of GSVA, manufacturing 20% and agriculture 14% (2023-24). Real GSDP grew 7.37% in 2024-25 (MoSPI). Bengaluru leads India in IT, start-ups, aerospace and biotechnology; the state is the top producer of coffee and silk. Strength: a knowledge economy hosting many global capability centres. Weakness: Bengaluru-centric growth, lagging Kalyana-Karnataka districts and drought-prone dryland farming.

Human Geography

Coastal Karavali, the Malnad of the Western Ghats, and the Deccan plateau (Bayaluseeme), drained by the Krishna and Kaveri. About 38.7% urban (2011); Bengaluru dominates urban growth and draws large in-migration. North interior districts face recurrent drought; Kodagu landslides and Bengaluru urban flooding are other hazards. Resources: iron ore (Ballari), gold (Hutti), forests and hydropower.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

The Greater Bengaluru Authority replaced BBMP in September 2025, overseeing five city corporations. A fresh statewide socio-educational (caste) survey began in September 2025. D.K. Shivakumar was sworn in as Chief Minister on 3 June 2026, succeeding Siddaramaiah.

Likely Interview Questions

1. What was the significance of Basavanna's Vachana movement for social reform?
2. How can Karnataka spread growth from Bengaluru to the Kalyana-Karnataka districts?
3. As DC of a drought-hit north Karnataka district, what immediate and long-term steps would you take?
4. Should state caste surveys guide reservation policy? Give a balanced view.
5. Is splitting Bengaluru into five corporations good urban governance?

Andhra Pradesh

India's first linguistic state, rice bowl and shrimp capital with a long coastline

Capital	Amaravati (sole capital, 2026 amendment)	**Formed**	1 Oct 1953 (Andhra State); 1 Nov 1956; present form 2 Jun 2014
Area	1,62,975 sq km (7th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	4.96 crore (10th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	997 / 67.35%	**Districts**	28 (since Jan 2026)
Official / main languages	Telugu; Urdu (second official)	**Per capita NSDP**	₹2,66,240 (2024-25)

History

Home to the Satavahanas, Ikshvakus, Eastern Chalukyas and Kakatiyas; Amaravati was a major Buddhist centre and Vijayanagara rule enriched Telugu literature. Potti Sriramulu's fatal 1952 fast forced the creation of Andhra State (1953), the first linguistic state, which merged with Telangana to form Andhra Pradesh (1956). The 2014 Reorganisation Act separated Telangana; after a three-capital plan, Parliament settled Amaravati as capital in 2026.

Society and Culture

Telugu is spoken by most people; Urdu is the second official language. Tribes such as Savara, Konda Dora and Chenchu inhabit the Eastern Ghats. Sankranti, Ugadi and Tirupati Brahmotsavam are major festivals. Kuchipudi dance, Kalamkari painting and Etikoppaka toys are famous, as are Guntur chilli dishes and Pootharekulu sweets. Kandukuri Veeresalingam championed widow remarriage, and Alluri Sitarama Raju led the Rampa tribal rebellion.

Economy

Services form about 43%, agriculture and allied about 35% and industry about 22% of GSVA (2025-26). It is a rice bowl and India's leading shrimp producer, also growing chillies, tobacco and fruits. Key industries include pharma, petrochemicals, steel at Visakhapatnam and automobiles near Anantapur. Per capita NSDP rose to ₹2,66,240 (2024-25). Strength: a 974 km coastline with ports. Weakness: a low manufacturing share and heavy post-bifurcation debt.

Human Geography

Three regions: fertile coastal Andhra with the Godavari-Krishna deltas, the drought-prone Rayalaseema plateau, and the forested Eastern Ghats agency tracts. Population concentrates in the deltas and cities like Visakhapatnam, Vijayawada and Guntur; about 29.5% was urban in 2011. People migrate from Rayalaseema and north Andhra to cities and the Gulf. Hazards include cyclones, floods and drought. Resources: barytes, limestone, beach-sand minerals and KG-basin gas.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Google announced a USD 15 billion AI hub and data centre at Visakhapatnam (October 2025). Severe Cyclone Montha crossed the coast near Narsapur (night of 28 October 2025). Parliament amended the 2014 Act to make Amaravati the sole capital (2026), and new Polavaram and Markapuram districts took effect in January 2026.

Likely Interview Questions

1. Why is Andhra State called India's first linguistic state, and what did Potti Sriramulu do?
2. What distinguishes Kuchipudi from other Indian classical dance forms?
3. How can Andhra Pradesh raise its manufacturing share after losing Hyderabad?
4. As Collector of a coastal district, how would you manage a severe cyclone warning?
5. Should a state have multiple capitals? Give your view using Amaravati's experience.

Telangana

India's youngest large state, Deccan heritage and Hyderabad's IT and pharma powerhouse

Capital	Hyderabad	**Formed**	2 Jun 2014 (AP Reorganisation Act)
Area	1,12,077 sq km (11th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	3.50 crore (12th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	988 / 66.54%	**Districts**	33 (since 2019)
Official / main languages	Telugu; Urdu (second official)	**Per capita NSDP**	₹3,79,751 (2024-25)

History

Ruled by the Satavahanas, the Kakatiyas of Warangal (including Rudrama Devi), the Qutb Shahis who founded Hyderabad (1591) and the Asaf Jahi Nizams. Hyderabad joined India after Operation Polo (1948), while the Telangana armed struggle (1946-51) fought feudal landlordism. Merged into Andhra Pradesh in 1956, the region saw statehood agitations in 1969 and from 2001, leading to statehood on 2 June 2014.

Society and Culture

Telugu dominates; Urdu is the second official language and Lambadi is widely spoken. Deccani culture blends Hindu and Islamic traditions. Bathukamma, Bonalu and the Sammakka-Saralamma jatara at Medaram, a huge tribal fair, are signature festivals. Perini Sivatandavam dance, Pochampally ikat, Bidriware and Cheriyal scroll paintings are well known, as are Hyderabadi biryani and haleem. Key movements include the peasant armed struggle and the Mulki (domicile) agitation.

Economy

Services make up about 66% of GSVA (2024-25), led by IT, global capability centres, pharma and vaccines in Hyderabad. Paddy, cotton and maize dominate farming, supported by lift irrigation. GSDP grew about 10% to roughly ₹16 lakh crore (2024-25), and per capita NSDP reached ₹3,79,751. Strength: Hyderabad's tech and life-sciences ecosystem. Weakness: growth concentrated around Hyderabad and a rising public debt burden.

Human Geography

Lies on the Deccan plateau, drained by the Godavari and Krishna, with forested hills in the north (Adilabad, Bhadradri) and dry uplands in the south. About 38.9% was urban in 2011, dominated by the Hyderabad metropolitan region. People migrate from Palamuru (Mahabubnagar) to cities and the Gulf. Hazards include drought, heatwaves and urban flooding. Resources: Singareni coal, limestone and granite.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

The Telangana Rising Global Summit (December 2025) released a Vision 2047 document targeting a USD 3 trillion economy, with MoUs of about ₹5.75 lakh crore. Bharat Future City is being planned south of Hyderabad. In February 2025, a roof collapse in the SLBC tunnel (Nagarkurnool) trapped eight workers.

Likely Interview Questions

1. What was the significance of the Telangana armed struggle of 1946-51?
2. Why is the Sammakka-Saralamma jatara important for tribal culture?
3. How can Telangana spread Hyderabad's growth to its backward districts?
4. As Collector, how would you handle a tunnel collapse trapping workers?
5. Can large welfare guarantees coexist with fiscal sustainability in Telangana? Give your view.

Gujarat

Industrial and trading powerhouse with India's longest coastline and Gandhi's birthplace

Capital	Gandhinagar	**Formed**	1 May 1960 (bifurcation of Bombay State)
Area	1,96,244 sq km (5th)	**Population (Census 2011)**	6.04 crore (9th)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	919 / 78.0%	**Districts**	34 (since Oct 2025)
Official / main languages	Gujarati, Hindi	**Per capita NSDP**	₹2,97,722 (2023-24)

History

Harappan sites Lothal and Dholavira mark early urbanism. The Mauryas, Western Kshatrapas, Maitrakas of Valabhi and Solankis followed; Somnath and Modhera reflect Solanki art. Ahmad Shah founded Ahmedabad in 1411. Surat became the Mughal-era port where the English set up a factory in 1613. Gandhi, Sardar Patel and the Kheda, Bardoli and Dandi (1930) struggles shaped the freedom movement. Gujarat was carved from Bombay State on 1 May 1960.

Society and Culture

Gujarati dominates, with Kutchi, Hindi and Bhili also spoken. Navratri garba, the Uttarayan kite festival and Rann Utsav draw wide participation. Patola silk, Rogan and Bandhani crafts, Pithora tribal art and Bhavai folk theatre are distinctive. Cuisine is largely vegetarian: dhokla, thepla, undhiyu. A strong mercantile and cooperative ethos produced Amul's milk movement under Verghese Kurien. Gandhi's Sabarmati Ashram remains a symbol of social reform.

Economy

GSDP reached about ₹27 lakh crore (2024-25), with estimated real growth of 7.4%. Manufacturing contributes 43.9%, services 36.6% and agriculture 19.5%. Key industries: petroleum refining (Jamnagar), chemicals, pharmaceuticals, diamonds and textiles (Surat), ports and solar energy. Crops include cotton, groundnut and cumin; dairying is strong. Strength: port-led industrial infrastructure. Weakness: health spending at 7.1% of the budget, below the 8% National Health Policy benchmark.

Human Geography

Three regions: alluvial mainland Gujarat, the Saurashtra (Kathiawar) peninsula and arid Kutch with its salt-marsh Rann. About 42.6% of people were urban in 2011, concentrated along the Ahmedabad–Vadodara–Surat corridor, which attracts interstate migrant workers. Hazards include earthquakes (Bhuj 2001), cyclones, droughts and floods. Resources: oil and gas, lignite, limestone, salt, and strong solar and wind potential.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

The Air India AI171 crash in Ahmedabad on 12 June 2025 killed 241 of 242 people on board. Vav-Tharad became Gujarat's 34th district on 2 October 2025. In November 2025, Ahmedabad was confirmed as host of the 2030 Commonwealth Games.

Likely Interview Questions

1. What does Dholavira reveal about Harappan town planning and water management?
2. How did the Amul cooperative model transform rural Gujarat, and can it be replicated?
3. Gujarat leads in manufacturing; why do some human development indicators lag behind?
4. As Collector of Kutch, how would you prepare for a severe cyclone landfall?
5. Is hosting the 2030 Commonwealth Games a sound use of public money? Justify.

Punjab

Land of five rivers, Sikh heritage, Green Revolution and India's granary

Capital	Chandigarh (shared Union Territory)	**Formed**	1 Nov 1966 (Punjab Reorganisation Act)
Area	50,362 sq km (19th among states)	**Population (Census 2011)**	2.77 crore (16th among states)
Sex ratio / Literacy (2011)	895 / 75.8%	**Districts**	23 (Malerkotla added 2021)
Official / main languages	Punjabi (Gurmukhi); Hindi	**Per capita NSDP**	₹2,09,452 (2024-25)

History

Cradle of Harappan sites like Ropar and Sanghol and Vedic Saptasindhu. Guru Nanak founded Sikhism; Guru Gobind Singh created the Khalsa (1699). Maharaja Ranjit Singh's empire fell to the British in 1849. Jallianwala Bagh (1919), the Gurdwara Reform and Ghadar movements, and Bhagat Singh shaped the freedom struggle. Partition in 1947 split Punjab; the 1966 reorganisation created present Punjab, followed by the militancy years of the 1980s.

Society and Culture

Sikhs form a majority, with Hindus, Dalit communities (about 32% Scheduled Castes, India's highest share) and others. Festivals include Baisakhi, Lohri, Gurpurabs and Hola Mohalla. Bhangra, Giddha, Sufi poetry of Bulleh Shah and Phulkari embroidery are celebrated. Langar embodies community service; cuisine features makki di roti, sarson da saag and lassi. Reform movements include the Singh Sabha, Gurdwara Reform and Ad-Dharm.

Economy

In 2023-24, services contributed about 47% of GSDP, manufacturing 28% and agriculture 26%. Punjab is a leading contributor of wheat and rice to the central pool; Ludhiana's hosiery, cycles and Jalandhar's sports goods anchor MSMEs. Real growth was 6.6% (2023-24). Strength: high farm productivity and irrigation. Weakness: debt near 47% of GSDP (2022-23), groundwater depletion and slow growth.

Human Geography

Regions: Shivalik foothills (Kandi belt), alluvial plains of the Bist-Doab, Bari-Doab and Malwa, and southwestern semi-arid tract. Over 80% of land is cultivated. Urbanisation is about 37%. Rural youth emigration abroad is high, while migrant labour arrives from Bihar and UP. Hazards: floods from Sutlej, Beas, Ravi and Ghaggar, groundwater decline and stubble-burning air pollution.

Recent Developments (2025–26)

Monsoon floods in August–September 2025 led to all 23 districts being declared flood-affected, hitting about 1,400 villages and over 4 lakh acres of crops. The 2026-27 Budget announced a monthly cash transfer for adult women and ₹10 lakh family health insurance under Mukhyamantri Sehat Yojana.

Likely Interview Questions

1. How did the Ghadar movement link Punjab's diaspora with India's freedom struggle?
2. How can Punjab diversify away from the wheat-paddy cycle without hurting farm incomes?
3. As DM of Sangrur, how will you curb stubble burning during the paddy season?
4. What drives large-scale youth emigration from Punjab, and how should the state respond?
5. Is free farm power sustainable for Punjab's finances and groundwater? Give your view.

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